The best laid plans of Cats and women

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Mature

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

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Catra (She-Ra), Lonnie (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra)

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sci fi, space, Pirates, Betrayal, Drama, Adora gets her moment in the spotlight, Catra has plans, will they work out, Things get revealed, Space Combat, Strategy, Angst, Anger, Violence

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The best laid plans of Cats and women

by ezmatron

Summary

Catra has a birds eye view of the system. She knows the movements of every ship and stellar body.... mostly.

She has a plan. She's going to knock the dominoes over. She's going to get that tech. She's going to GET Adora... for her own good, of course.

What could go wrong...?

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

Chapter 1

Hull breach: Deck 4

Hull breach: Deck 7

Hull breach: Deck 8

Fire in: Hydroponics

Fire in: cargo bay 3

Fire in: galley

Fire in: habitation section 3

Escape pods: compromised

Damage report: Port batteries operating at 46%

Damage report: Starboard batteries operating at 63%

Torpedo launchers: Offline

Point defence: Offline

Reactor at 33% stability

Coolant lines: ruptured

Venting in process

"Where the hell did they come from?" shrieked Mermista from the Captain's chair. Around her, the bridge of the *Sea Gate* was in chaos. Control panels blazed with emergency warning indicators and the red of the emergency lighting cast everything in a hellish hue.

"I'm reading five frigates and a single Destroyer. Sensors are shot, though," called out one of the crew, "Point defence is down; their strike fighters are maneuvering for another pass."

Mermista cursed, "And the freighters?"

"We're blocking the enemy's firing angles, but it looks like two of the frigates are moving to intercept."

The Pirate Captain huffed, "This was supposed to be an easy swipe"…

Another of the crew, her gills flared in agitation warbled out a monotone realisation, "It was a trap"…

Mermista gritted her teeth, "Duh. A resupply convoy, a frigate escort… it looked like any other routine horde resupply."

t'd been weeks - the Horde presence had been minimal, edge of the system, mostly. The *Sea Gate* had managed to slip in and out of the system pretty easily, striking at the Merchant Guild shipping lanes. But this had proven too tempting. A chance to swipe some military hardware and bloody the nose of Horde? Mermista hadn't been able to resist.

What had been weird was how cautious Sea Hawk had been - Huntara had even backed him up. The Horde had been quiet. Sea Hawk thought that meant they were planning something. He wasn't usually so cautious, which had given Mermista pause. She had *almost* listened to him.

Almost.

Instead she'd gotten irritated and sent him on a milk run to keep him out of the way.

She'd felt confident in their ability. Adora had been keeping her end of the bargain with Angella - none of the Waste pirates were knocking on their door;the Rebel supply lines were good (Even if Mermista scoffed at the idea of it even *being* a rebellion. They were just refugees and exiles. No real *fight back* against the Horde)

And the few Frigates they'd tracked that belonged to the Horde fleet seemed dilapidated and, frankly, embarrassing. Which, she now realised, had been what the Horde had wanted them to think.

And that was surprising. The Horde didn't DO tactical subtlety. It was the HORDE. They spammed drones and firepower and just bludgeoned their way in. Yes, the odd *tactical* feint to draw you into a better firing position. But a *strategic* ploy? That was rare. And usually that was with larger fleets - grander manoeuvers. She knew that - her father, a Privateer *lord* of some renown, had always said to avoid the core systems for that very reason - because those Admirals were cunning and smart. You had to be, to survive the politicking. That translated to military approaches as much as dodging the Emperor's mad whims.

The periphery fleets were scrappy but were, ultimately, bullies - they relied on opportunity and their immediate reinforcements.

So, now that her ship was basically being split in two, she was forced to face up to the fact that she had been out-fought. Her small fleet of capture-freighters that had been in position to haul away the cargo containers from the Horde freighters were now at maximum burn to try to get distance, before their FTL drives could spool up.

Which meant she had to keep buying them time. Yeah, some might argue her Battlecruiser was of more value, but if she cut and ran in a *combat* ship then her crew would mutiny. Her *wider* crew. The *ship*'s crew were probably still considering it.

"Captain, energy readings from the Enemy Destroyer. Its main gun is charging!"

Mermista cursed, "Orient the shield, well have to try to weather it. Surviving batteries, target the frigates - we cant scratch the Destroyer, no point trying. Sensors, any incoming?"

A bloodied crewman looked up from the sensor suite and grimaced, "We're getting poor readings - a few of the antennas look burned out. But...nothing on long-wave, subspace..."

"Comms are intermittent," called out another crewman, "We've got a response to our mayday - Brightmoon is looking to re-task a few wings"...

Mermista shook her head, "Theyll get torn to pieces. Engineering, any chance of a miracle with the jump drive?"

" *It's… *cough* it's a burn down here ma'am. Half the deck is melted. We've got breaches in the reactor. I…. we can push for a burn, but jumping's off the table."*

Mermista sagged in her seat and closed her eyes.

"Where the *fuck* is Adora?"

---

76 hours earlier

"So, we have, what? Full visuals?" Catra squatted on the table in Entrapta's planet-side lab and squinted at an adjacent monitor. The Engineer swivelled on her chair, arms outspread and grinned.

"SO MUCH MORE! Spectrum analysis, energy tracking, passive sensors! A full, real time, 3d map of the entire system! The previous survey team had it calibrated for *mining* and *materials* but they didnt even take advantage of some of the in-built functions. I mean, why even bother going for survey systems and then just using the *default settings!* I managed to get transmission latency down by"…

"Ok, ok," Catra chuckled, "So, with what Lonnie got, the net setup… we can track the Praetorian. And the Rebels."

"Oh yes," cackled Entrapta, "WE CAN DO the thing!"

" *Ugh. All sensors operating at optimal capacity. Generating full scope mapping of the system. Stand by."*

Catra grinned at the speaker, "Thank you Weaver."

“ *Insincerity does not suit you, Captain. I believe you have things to be doing, beyond failing?”*

“Ouch, harsh. Sticks and stones, W eaver. go and enjoy all that extra bandwidth you get from being in a Destroyer .”

The silence from the speaker made Catra’s grin turn a bit nastier. Entrapta clicked her tongue and swivelled again, “She is helping us, you know?”

“Only as long as it’ s good for her. We have a good arrangement *now* but Weaver As is are”…

“Homicidal. Iknow . The whole Lightspinner program was a mess waiting to happen. Buuuut that’s what happens when you get disgruntled coders involved with no detailed brief!” Entrapta huf fed and glanced around, “Is Scorpia joining us? I need food. She always brings good food.”

“Just go to the commissary ,” Catra said with a snort.

“But they dont do the food *right* .”

"Then ask them. You're head of Projects Trapta. Throw your weight. Or do you want me to?"

A knock on the door made them turn and Lonnie stepped into the lab cautiously. She looked tired - frankly, she'd looked that way since being rescued. The medics had given her a clean bill of health, but she seemed a lot quieter compared to before. Catra watched the pilot for a moment then sighed. Lonnie cleared her throat, "You uh… wanted to see me ma'am?"

Catra nodded, "Wanted your input, Lieutenant. We're getting near-live data for most of the system now. Your hack-job actually got us some good FF dumps, so we can track a lot of ships. *Plus* we think we have a few good reads on some *other* movement. But you were there, so, I wanted to pick your brains."

Lonnie glanced at Entrapta who returned her look with a puzzled expression. Then the techie cackled, "Not LITERALLY!"

The pilot flinched then relaxed and Catra chuckled again, "Yeah we aren't gonna wire you up. We have the net up. I just need an idea on things."

A holo-map sat in the centre of the room - currently, it showed a very zoomed-out image of the system. Catra hopped off the desk and stalked towards the map, while Lonnie moved carefully into the room. The pilot frowned at the display and reached out before

pausing. Catra made a *go ahead* motion and Lonnie zoomed the image in.

"So, uh..what am I looking at? Or for?"

Catra shrugged, "Theories. Another perspective. Intel have tagged some of these things - those blue routes look like regularly travelled areas: freighters and supply ships. That green dot there, that's the mining station"...

"Yeah recognise the layout and background...uh-uh. You got a full scan of that Battlecruiser?"

"Yep. And tracking its movements is stupid easy now," Catra smirked and shrugged, "These guys are...Well, lazy is one way of putting it. I mean, they do the right evasive jump patterns buuuut..their counter sensor game is *shockingly* bad."

Lonnie moved the map around as she took in the various routes. She noticed the planetoid she'd ended up on and the faint line of a ship-route in red, then another in blue. She pointed to it and quirked a brow at Catra. The Captain shrugged and Lonnie chewed her lip, "A rescue ship?" she offered.

Catra eyed her and harrumphed, "Well, that was *our* trail. You said there were no survivors though."

Lonnie deadpanned and shrugged, "Nope. Salvage mission maybe. Or recoverin' the bodies. Comms said there was a VP aboard."

"Yeah you said," Catra shrugged, then watched as Lonnie dragged the map, following the blue trail. The pilot snorted as it hit the sensor shadow.

"Well that's convenient."

"Ahhh well." Entrapta grinned from across the room. She tapped away at some of the keys and a few more lines appeared *inside* the shadow. Not all the way in, but definitely marketing some clearer routes, "Longer range scans, plus some predictive mapping *and* visual markers of possible safe routes *through* the debris field has given us THIS!"

Lonnie let out a low whistle, "Niiiice," then she squinted, "Though your sensors may need tweaking."

Entrapta blinked, "Um"…

Catra actually pulled back in surprise and she glanced at the Engineer, waiting for the indignant blowback. But Entrapta was just watching Lonnie. Or rather was watching what Lonnie was staring at. Catra turned to peer at the spot and frowned.

It wasn't an empty patch of space - it was something else. The sensors hadn't really marked it as it was just an absence of data. Not empty space but an *absence* ...of anything. Background radiation; radiation trails; heat. NOTHING.

Lonnie pursed her lips, "Uh...yeah, so, you may wanna look"...

"Entrapta, can you?" Catra interrupted. The Engineer nodded vigorously, then spun back to her terminal. The Captain zoomed the map out a little as the *absence* was brought to the top of the filter list. The other trails and map markers dimmed, while the absence was marked in yellow.

A web of trails suddenly lit up across the map. They all led to a couple of what could be termed *entry* points on the sensor shadow - but they actually led further than the *other* trails. Catra let out a low whistle. Lonnie, for her part, looked confused, "What is that?"

"It could be...our mystery visitor?" Entrapta offered, pausing as Catra shot her a sharp look.

Lonnie frowned, "That tug with the weird...energy stuff?"

Catra chewed her lip, "Maybe. Or...something else. Entrapta, didn't Ado- that ship have an energy reading?"

The Engineer nodded she flicked it into the filters and sighed, "Still no matches on the sensor web."

"Well..it didn't show up until we poked the hornets nest with her and that ship went haywire," mused Catra. She looked at Lonnie, "Good spot. Now , anything else?"

"Uh," Lonnie squinted at the map again, "Well..We can see routes for that ship..so we know where it goes. We've got access and potential patrol routes, plus points of interest for traffic density," she rubbed her chin, "Uh..ambush sites, maybe? Or"...

"Or..we know where to *avoid* ."

Lonnie nodded slowly, then pointed at the remains of the wrecked planetoid. "That's weird..lots of yellow routes heading there..but look at the overlay. It's a match but there's lines that go *nowhere.* Dead ends."

"Hmm..which could indicate similar energy signatures"..mused Entrapta. Lonnie nodded slowly. She looked at Catra again, "Is… that all, ma'am?"

"No..I wanted your input on..external infiltration. I have reason to believe an operative from another faction of the Military is here…

working *against* our interest. Iwant you to study the map, see if you cant D routes or movements that seem.at odds with the patterns. Ykow , non piratey stuff, intersects with other movements."

"Y es ma'am. But.again, why me?"

"Because you're a good pilot, you know your stuf f around combat flights and tactical movement;you know about keeping under the RADAR. So, Im hoping youll spot the tricks someone being *sneaky* might use. You spotted Ador... *her* movements already. See if you cant spot a second one. Entrapta, give Lonnie access to the map. Im gonna go grab some freakin' chow . Starving."

Lonnie nodded absently as Catra left, then peered at the map again. Her gut clenched, not for the first time since her rescue. Her gaze travelled over each line, each moving blip, each highlighted settlement or mining outpost. For the first time she didnt see these things and think: *targets* .

She bit her lip and folded her arms, then drew a shuddering breath. She looked at the patterns and tried to force down the guilt and worry.

She had a job to do.

Now

“Pirate vessel Sea-Gate. Power down and prepare to be boarded. We want to avoid unnecessary bloodshed. So, for the sake of your crew, well, um, power down. Now.”

Mermista gritted her teeth and yelled out commands. The vessel on screen flashed as a bolt of actinic red light lanced forth. The *Sea Gate* shuddered under the impact and several consoles ruptured. Men screamed as fires broke out across the bridge.

“Any functional torpedoes or missiles - target those frigates, then angle us towards the destroyer. Ramming speed!”

---

52 hours prior

Catra’s grin was predatory as she reviewed the findings from the intel team and Lonnie’s own in-progress updates. She checked the itinerary of the new arrivals from out-of-system (*thank you Hordak*).

The picture was clear - a main operating base *somewhere* within the sensor shadow. That had pretty much been a given. What *was* interesting was what had happened when she'd sent some more aggressive probing actions against those identified routes - just some fighter patrols, initially, then a frigate. Well, a *pirate* frigate she'd managed to get from out of system, to come here with the promise of *riches* . Via a carefully dropped hint through a less than trustworthy contact.

With the fighters deployed that usually summoned some Privateers as the response team- mercs - fairly quickly , too. They'd managed to snag one freighter at least, before the mercs came in guns blazing.

But if there was a more substantial threat? She did her scary tug-boat-becomes-death thing and would go to *town* . The Pirate frigate had been crippled within minutes. A horde Frigate she'd tasked managed to jump away , abandoning the target. Adora hadn't hailed the ship, she'd just gone straight at them.

Some of the signatures in system were making excursions to the systems periphery and beyond - their FFs changed, but the recorded energy readings meant they were able to sync up with the Horde sensor net in neighbouring systems and matched some Pirate raids to those vessels. It seemed this system had raiders who the locals weren't exactly *anti* . And those raiders weren't averse to hitting the odd sole Horde supply ship or corvette. But Adora *didn't* .

That trail stayed firmly *in system* .

Adora seemed to mostly be keeping to the mining sites in the belt. And she certainly seemed to be just keeping a low profile. The odd combat conflict where her energy readings went from masked to *very* visible. And those journeys to the wrecked planetoid... that would need *some* further study.

What was more troubling was that there was no clear sign of the Praetorian. But then again, the assassin could have come in on a civilian transport and be making use of local traffic. Shuttles were a *lot* harder to track - unless they were in closer proximity to the sensors it was a lot harder to see if there was a sneaky one-man-kill-squad on the prowl.

The plus point there though was that the Praetorian wouldn't have access to a comprehensive sensor solution like they had; they'd be reliant on intel from locals, or whatever they could scrounge by raiding local sensor data banks. A LOT slower. Yeah, Praetorians were scary... but this one hadn't arrived with a ship it seemed; or a support fleet.

So that gave Catra an advantage. And she had a multi-step plan in mind.

She knew where Adora went.

She knew Adora was acting as a guardian of sorts.

She knew the movements of every ship in the system.

She knew what they were looking for.

She just needed to make sure she laid the snares *properly.*

Breadcrumbs

Chapter Summary

Adora remembers. Adora accepts.

Adora is observed.

Chapter Notes

TW: Minor mentions / references to historical trauma / interrogation / torture. Nothing graphic but implied.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

36 hours prior

Adora rolled her shoulders and squinted at the readout on *Swiftwind's* console. She'd been mining for about 15 hours straight and it was finally starting to kick in. With all her various *upgrades* and training sleep wasn't as vital. Or rather , it was, but she tended to just *push through* . She told herself that mining was meditative, calming.

It really wasn't. It was *dull* .

With a grunt, she rubbed at her tired eyes and checked the readout again. She could have sworn there was a proximity alert, but it looked clear now. *Swiftwind* had a pretty good sensor suite due to the *other* updates that he had but some things could hide from it. Well, mostly.

She switched the mining lasers off with a flick of a switch and leaned back in her flight-chair, eyes glued to the readout. Fifteen minutes ticked past as she blinked rapidly, trying to keep her mind focused. She felt distracted lately. Of course, the fact she wasn't sleeping *could* be impacting things. But it wasn't like she had time to rest.

Patrols. Mining. Answering distress calls.

Research…

She cursed as that last one floated up in her addled mind. She did need to make a *trip.*

"No time like the present," she muttered to herself. Maybe being away from the station for a while would be good. Everyone there just wanted to talk, or celebrate. Yes, there was plenty to be excited about: the hordes seemed to be sitting on the fringes; freighters were mostly unmolested; and the pirates were pretty sparse.

Truthfully, she enjoyed the parties. Sort of. For about ten minutes.

Then the noise began to grate; the proximity of people made her hackles rise and her neck prickle; the touching and contact made her flinch. Old training and ingrained behaviours made her retreat to corners with good lines of sight.

Part of her *desperately* wanted to be able to just relax. To get involved. But there was danger. Always *danger*. Huntara had shown that a few days ago. She hadn't really met Adora, but got *feisty* when she recognised Adora's jacket as an old Horde style. She'd gotten *argumentative*.

She'd ended up with concussion and Mermista had gotten in Adora's face. Then backed the hell away as soon as Adora had looked her straight in the eye. Not much made the Pirate Princess flinch. Adora just looking at her was apparently enough, though.

So, instead of being aboard the station, listening to Bow play his recovered guitar, or talking quietly with Glimmer about the latest rumours, she sat in the void, digging away for ores. So, perhaps it *was* a good time to try some more relic diving.

Adora rolled her shoulders again and hissed as the muscles cramped briefly. With a wince she stretched out her neck and sighed as the tension released. Her body was already dealing with the problem, but cramp was cramp. The silent and deadly pain you never expected. Adora chuckled at her own lame humour.

A memory bubbled up: mismatched eyes staring at her with mirth as Adorar stretched her calf muscles. A particularly intensive sparring session had led to Catra helping Adora cool down, pressing her foot back and mocking her for her *inflexibility*. How Adora wished she'd had the courage then to show her how flexible she could've been.

But that was a possibility consigned to the past. A memory tainted by the reality of Catra. Of what she'd *done* .

Adora closed her eyes and sagged back into her chair. She swallowed thickly and licked her dry lips. Her fists clenched and she slammed one down onto the side of the battered flight chair. Slowly, carefully, she drew in a shuddering breath and choked back a strangled sob. She clenched her teeth and exhaled then sat back up.

Her eyes narrowed as she took in the sensor readings, then typed in the command code that would allow *Swiftwind* to auto-connect to the ore-container nearby. The small mining craft hummed as it turned and docked with a faint shudder. Adora stood and moved around the cramped cockpit and back into her sparse and narrow living quarters as *Swiftwind* turned on auto-pilot. The engines came to life as the ship trundled through an auto-planned route. The ship had enough autonomy to make on the fly adjustments, just in case her route was being tracked by observers. She had faith in the dust field and sensor shroud around the base though.

Catra had a ramshackle ship, out of commission, but seemed to *somehow* still be active. Probably the local Horde commander had given her a reprieve.

The blonde slumped into her tiny bunk and blew out a breath. She mulled over the actions the past few weeks - that surprise attack on the liberated mining base;the rescue of Glimmer;the withdrawal and silence of the Horde ships. She was paranoid by nature, so she was waiting for the other shoe to drop.and set of f a landmine.

But no major assets had entered the system. No carriers, no new destroyers, battleships: nothing. It was likely the Horde wanted to *ignore* the place. Which could be likely - the Horde either crushed anywhere they were defeated or wrote it off as not worth the bother. Catra could have been deemed an acceptable "loss" in terms of reputation - it was a reflection on *her* not on the *Horde* .

And that made Adora feel a little guilty. She'd hoped Catra would have cut and run. But the girl was nothing if not *stubborn* it seemed. It looked like she'd retained her command in some way . Which meant she had reported *something* back. But the lack of major response to Adora's display either meant the Horde hadn't believed her, or they were letting Catra try to "redeem" herself. Which was probably futile.

Probably.

Catra was probably just doing reconnaissance, then. Which meant a Horde fleet *could* appear. But, again, that was a problem that fell into the "Maybe" column.

Adora had a *lot* of columns in her brain: scenarios, strategies, contingency plans. It was exhausting when she went through her overthinking moments. Most of the time she just went with things. Kept it simple. That was how most of her missions had been managed by The Intelligence Division. Bare bones information, wide remit on how to accomplish things. Over-prescription of tasks led to too many failure points.

Of course, it was in her nature to overthink, to plan. It was why she was successful; it was also why she'd been able to get *out* in the end: that obsessive attention to detail.

But it also meant she didn't *sleep* all that well.

The proximity alert bleeped and Adora blinked rapidly once more. With a groan she sat up and realised she'd zoned out again. With a string of muttered curses she staggered back to the flight chair and leaned across it. Her fingers were a blur as she cycled through menu options on the small secondary monitor in front of her, the green text on the screen rattling past at the speed of someone who knows the menus by heart.

A few key presses later and the ore-container disengaged with a hiss and began an auto-approach to the station visible through the cockpit window. She winced as the transmitter beeped with an incoming hail. With a sigh she acknowledged, "*Swiftwind* here."

"Ah, um, hello Adora… uh… are you docking?"

"Nom standard ore dropoff f.and hello Sandra."

"Oh, um, hey. SO, your clearance checks out and… well, transmitting you the new Ident codes for the IFF."

Adora huffed and allowed a small smile to creep across her face. Sandra was one of the station control staff. A flustered little thing. She'd probably either go to pieces in a fight or end up with the highest kill-count on the station. Adora wasn't sure which was more likely. All she knew was that Sandra kept trying to talk to her. It was flattering but also *irritating* .

Adora didn't need any more friends. Or anything *else* . Some said she was oblivious, but she really wasn't.

It's hard to get interested in someone when your heart is just cold.

"Thanks Sandra. Just put me in as on patrol if anyone asks. I may swing by in a few hours."

" *Sure. Sure. Um, Glimmer… I mean, Lieutenant Mon asked if you could swing by the bar…"*

Adora smirked at the hint of forced nonchalance in the young woman's tone.

"Uh huh? She and her husband?"

" *Um, not sure. Assume… umm.."*

"Tell them I'll drop by when I'm back. Bit busy now. Some sensor ghosts, you know how it is. Bye," and with that, Adora disconnected the comm and tapped in another set of auto-co-ordinates.

No doubt it was another *check in* by the self proclaimed "BFS". She liked Glimmer and Bow. They were tolerable. Kind, even. But they were also anchors. And she needed to be able to cut anchors loose if she needed to.

But the thought of *that* was getting harder to stomach each day. Yes, she could imagine spacing Angella fifteen different ways. DT too! But Glimmer? Bow?

That was harder. The idea of them fighting in a corridor, being overwhelmed while Adora set a new course out of the system?

Well, it had been a fixture of quite a recent nightmare.

And that irked Adora. She *definitely* needed a distraction.

She rubbed her eyes again and missed the momentary flash on the proximity tracker as *Swiftwind* cleared the dust-cloud around the sensor-shroud. With another tired exhalation, Adora slumped onto her bunk and zoned for a moment, ears waiting for the alert. Slowly her brain fogged over as exhaustion settled in.

Images of green fluid and needles and pain and whispers and questions always the questions - why why why why? Be better, be stronger, be loyal. Look at the lights, tell us how many lights. There five lights. Not four. Five. Learn. Obey. Listen.

The green. Always more green. The shocks, the pain, never ending. The monotone voice from the speakers, the Weaver talking, constantly, the same words burned into her brain.

Adora jolted upright and sucked in a ragged breath. She clutched a fist her chest and tried to regulate her breaths. It was hard.

Her hair stuck to her head, lank and sweaty as she counted backwards. Her shoulders shook and she worked her jaw. Her eyes stung and she bit back the sob.

Another reason she dreaded sleeping.

With a shaky exhalation, she stood and moved towards the flight chair, where she carefully eased herself down. Her muscles were all tense again and her eyes ached. She blinked owlishly and checked the chronometer then chuckled darkly. She'd managed a couple of hours of sleep at least.

Below the ship lay the shattered remnants of the planetoid. Fragments drifted from it, leading off into the rest of the belt, while colourful remnants of the planet's former atmosphere drifted like a comet's trail behind the shattered sphere. Adora cracked her knuckles and switched the craft to manual, then directed *Swiftwind* down, through the dust and debris. Her HUD lit up with warnings and fuzzy sensor ghosts. She ignored them now; the first time she'd been through this way, lost and alone and on her third system move, she'd felt harried and jumpy .

She'd even opened fire on *something* in the swirl of kaleidoscopic dust and gas. There had been a thing in the dust - a light, a shape of something. Insubstantial as mist, however .

Adora was used to them - remnants of some technology from the planet's past. Or genuine hulks that were lost in the field, glimpses of wrecks from a forgotten war.

Adora had spoken to Angella, briefly, about the planetoid. She kept it *vague* , even though the Administrator clearly knew something. It had been whole until a few years prior. Then some survey team had gone down to it and everything had changed for the system. Ironically , that change had made it perfect for the "rebels."

And it had given Adora access to something fantastical. She wasn't sure if it was a blessing or a curse, but she felt compelled either way.

Slowly, she descended, passing vast chunks of rock larger than orbital habitats;continent sized fragments and wreckage of some grand cataclysm.

The planet hadnt exploded - it had *crumbled* apart, really. As if it had been held together against its will. Parts had been flung into space, further and further away and around the systems orbital path. But in doing so, something had been revealed. And Adora had found it, though not entirely by accident.

Something had drawn her to the system. Shed been on the run, yes. But something here had called to her. By that point she had already equipped *Swiftwind* to a ridiculous degree- through theft and mercenary work, mostly. But what she found here had changed *everything* .

The vast, main bulk of the planetoid loomed ahead and she angled *Swiftwind* in past several large free-floating hunks of rock. Lights flared ahead - white-blue and harsh. Carefully Adora guided *Swiftwind* in to the newly revealed passage. Her small craft drifted down a long corridor-like structure, then settled onto artificially smooth stone.

With a sigh Adora relaxed. More light flickered around her vessel as a bubble of strange white energy formed a dome around the shuttle. The blonde glanced about, then stood and rifled through the cabin locker, pulling out a rebreather kit and an oxygen tank.

Not that Adora didn't trust ancient atmospheric technology , of course.

Well, really she did. After all, that's what kept *Swiftwind* punching above his weight class. WAY above. But still, it never hurt to be careful.

Pulling on her jacket, Adora then set about attaching the mask and canister, then punched the hatch release, before she stepped out into the stale air of the cavern.

Again, she missed the flicker on the sensor screen. And, as she headed towards a shattered stairway, she didn't spot the movement down the corridor to open space - a small, insignificant flash of metal.

As Adora checked her small base camp, where she'd setup a generator, winch and rappelling system, she was unaware of the feral grin stretching across a feline face half a system away as her image was beamed to a monitor on a planetary base.

"Heyyyyy Adora."

Chapter End Notes

Can you see where this might be going yet?

Just fleshing things out as we see more of our poor , broken, blonde baby.

Well get some more "present" excitement next chapter! If you spot any glaring issues, let me know!

Caught like a rat in a maze

Chapter Summary

Adora delves for treasures and answers.

Mermista faces a choice.

Catra springs her trap.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

35 hours prior

Adora's footfalls echoed through the musty corridor, its edges made dimmer by the barely-there light of her glowing hand-lamp. It wasn't much of a flash-like, more a ridiculously bright glow-stick-cum-flare. She took her time as she picked her way between blocks of rubble and various cables that she'd painstakingly threaded through the complex

She paused in front of a large mural on a cracked wall and tilted her lamp. She'd passed it dozens of times, but couldn't help stopping. Faint traceries of white light flickered over the surface of the mural, a sign of the remaining power in the system of the ancient ruin still struggling to function.

The picture reminded her of the various propaganda paintings and posters that dotted the corridors and streets of Imperial installations

and civilian hubs. The sorts that depicted faceless soldiers hoisting a flag, or battling some nebulous menace. Noble men and women clasping their chests, staring at a visage of the Emperor, or saluting a flyby of some Imperial Shrike fighter craft.

This was similar, if much simpler - an image of almost-stick figure simplicity, like a stained glass window on some back-water temple. A stylised representation of a man, raising a blade above his head. A hooded figure, bowed nearby, body styled to resemble a skeleton. Perhaps a corpse? A sign of the man's victory and slaying his foe? To the man's left, a great feline and a collection of human figures stood, clearly in some sort of solidarity.

The image brought a wave of nostalgia over Adora, swiftly followed by a cold anger. Memories of when Catra and her had huddled in the bunkhouse, dreaming of bringing peace and order;being saviours for the colonies;fighting grotesque pirates and monstrous space abominations.

But oh how *that* had changed. Recruits got randomly selected to attend live missions as observers. And Adora had *seen* the reality. Her scores meant she was in line for a piloting course *and* office corps. Which meant she got to stand on a bridge and watch a cruiser bombard an agri-world for *not paying taxes.*

And then... And then.

When she'd tried to get Catra to leave? When she'd tried to explain, tried to convince her?

Adora's eyes screwed up at the mental crack of the whip. She had kept her eyes open back then, bitten down on the wooden *bit* the Sergeant had handed her. The man had had the decency to look a little shame-faced. And she remembered staring into the crowd of cadets. Right at Catra.

Catra who had looked furious, but resolute.

At least to start with.

Adora had taken the hits and watched as Catra had shaken and tried to move forwards, only to be hauled back in line by the other cadets. Adora had glared and shaken her head. To her credit, Catra hadn't broken eye contact. She had looked angry again as Adora was hauled away, towards the guard house.

And...and into her *future*.

Adora hissed through her teeth and punched the mural. Cracks spiderwebbed across the surface of the wall - the strance, almost ceramic gloss that covered the masonry now like eggshell in its fragility.

With a shuddered breath, the blonde turned to continue on her way. She meandered through dark, cavernous halls, strewn with fallen pillars, then made her way down a side corridor. Carefully she squeezed between the steel plates of a blast door she'd wedged open with a crate. Inside she drew another breath and adjusted the pack slung across her shoulder.

"Time to get to work."

Now

The *Sea Gate* thrummed as it powered towards the Destroyer. Smoke and atmosphere billowed out into the void of space. Functional weapons spewed forth their payloads until the bins were empty, traces of slugs, lasers and torpedoes arcing towards the mighty bulk of the vessel and its escorts.

The shields of the enemy ship flickers as the rounds and projectiles beat against it. A red glow built up at the fore, whilst its main guns continued to heap on the punishment. More of the *Sea Gate* was stripped away by each subsequent strike. The Pirate vessel shuddered and lurched as one engine suddenly gave out and the vessel's course shifted into a curve.

Chance was clearly still on Mermista's side - the Destroyer fired it's main gun at the same moment. Instead of a strike on the prow , which would have likely split the ship in two, the beam lanced and bored a gouge through a flank. The strike sent rippled explosions through the vessel, knocking the trajectory into a further spiral.

It didn't go *all* the Horde's way, of course - a few torpedoes snaked past the point defence guns and slammed home on the enemy frigate's closing in on the fleeing freighters. One warship tumbled as it vented atmosphere and sought to correct itself. The second frigate had to break off pursuit to shoot down the next wave of torpedoes, then sped up.

"Ma'am, looks like they'll intercept the rear-most freighter ," coughed the sensor operator."

"We're adrift, engines out. Weapons partially operational."

Mermista cursed, "Give me control. All of you. Shuttles, escape pods, enviro suits with beacons, what ever the hell you can find. If you have to surrender, do so. But say you were press ganged. The Horde do *not* treat pirates well. Maybe... maybe they'll have clemency."

They all knew that was a lie.

" *ADVENTCHAAAA!"* the cracked cry broke through the speakers. Mermista's eyes boggled as the cracked viewscreen flickered to life,

showing a small wing of strike fighters as they slipped in from warp. The motley collection of ships dove towards the pursuing frigate, missiles away as they closed. The frigate rolled and tried to bring its dorsal weapons to bear, but its engines took the brunt of the strikes and it spun under its own momentum.

The wing turned and began a run towards the Destroyer. The Horde fighters turned their attention from the crippled *Sea Gate* and angled towards the incoming newer threat.

"Sea Hawk, what the *hell* are you doing," shrieked Mermista, "I explicitly told you!"

"I'm sorry my love, of siren of the space lanes, the channel is a bit choppy. I could have sworn you said 'come, post haste!' after all, Brightmoon said so too."

"Ugh, I *never* use the words 'post haste'. Like, I think I'd… That's NOT the point! Get out of here, they'll tear you apart!"

" *Then it'll be for a cause worth dying for. Just…. Make sure the story is a suitably heroic one?"* the man's voice was filled with a forced cheer. On the screen, his fighter, the *Dragon's Daughter 7 or 8* (Mermista honestly wasn't sure) barreled in and opened fire. Two Horde drones exploded in a shower of sparks and shrapnel. The gunships and fighters behind Sea Hawk began their own dance, but the *idiot* seemed to have a different goal in mind. The *Sea Gate's* trajectory had taken it past the Destroyer , which was now pivoting,

trying to bring its main gun to bear once more. Sea Hawk was making a direct line for the behemoth.

"What.what are you doing?" Mermista swallowed as she watched the screen.

" *Saving the damsel in distress. Now, please… if you wouldn't mind… saving yourself. I don't think my ship has the capacity for the whole crew, so I'm afraid… I'm afraid you'll have to find a way. I'll keep them occupied as long as I can."*

"Sea Hawk !..

"Mermista…. For once, please… please can you do as I ask? Get to safety,. Save your people. One man over the mission? No. Save them. I'll see you… when I see you."

The comm went dead. Mermista gripped the edge of her command chair, then punched the comm, "Engineering?"

"Mma'am. W e… main engines are down, but the jump drive has… five minutes…"

" Make it two. Gunnery , give what cover we can. Anything left," she swallowed thickly, "Buy him some time."

34 hours prior

The sleek shape of an Imperial Horde troop carrier slid through the gaseous debris of the planetoid. A field shimmered around it as it moved, like oil. A pain of spidery drones drifted alongside, then shot forwards, angled towards the entryway to the cavern. They anchored against the entrance, out of sight of the still and silent *Swift Wind* .

Slowly, the troop ship settled and began to approach.

Adora blew a strand of hair from her face and sat back on her haunches. A grumble escaped her lips as she surveyed the tangle of cables and strance, almost crystalline circuitry before her.

The room she was in was, she was fairly sure, a record room. It wasn't grand enough to be a control centre - she'd found one of those. It had had a broken dais, along with several burnt out rows of what had, probably, been terminals for holographic interfaces. She knew the tech of this place relied *heavily* on holograms - the few, still functional, terminals she'd found had shown that. There'd even been some sort of automated helper, all fuzzy outline and looping commentary. She'd scrapped it and set up some excavation equipment in there, to help carve out old circuit boards. It was next on her "to-do" list once this room was done with.

The runic script was strangely familiar to Adora. Or rather it was familiar *now* .

t hadnt been when sheˆd picked up that first *upgrade* for Swift Wind. Of course, it hadnt been a n upgrade for him then - itˆd been something that had allowed her to *escape* .

Her mind swam at the memory - a room in some old mansion on a rainy world. Blood stained the oak panelled floor where an old man lay dead. Adora had been there to collect an item, but found out it had been a trap by a retrieval team. Oh the *item* was real - theyˆd been there for that too - good old two for one’mission. t was just her luck that the old man had had the item *out* of its container. Clearly curiosity had gotten the better of him - he had been supposed to hand it over and receive payment.

The retrieval team had been told *not* to pay. Of course, they had underestimated her, thinking her a simple runaway.

orde ntelligence - so paranoid it didnt brief its operatives properly . tˆd still been tough, though.

After the fight Adora had limped to the box and reached to close it, to take it to the dealer who had hired her to courier it. Her in her junker mining vessel and with her clearly false records.

But the strange artefact, a bracer, had glowed with a strangely hypnotic light. And when Adora touched it it had *vanished* .

Into her .

The flashes of memory after that were jumbled, like a fever dream - the journey to the port a distant, foggy dream. She'd clambered into *Swift Wind* , but he had rumbled and his core had failed - clear sabotage by the retrieval team, in case she'd evaded them. Of course, there were none left to take advantage of that fact.

And when she'd touched the engine, to try to fix him, well…

She'd woken up a few days later , on another planet in a different system, way off the grid. An old ruin outside the vessel. And so had started her side-line in *archaeology* . Turned out the artefact had downloaded a bit of data into her. Entirely by chance - likely because she had certain *upgrades* courtesy of the benevolence of his Imperial Majesty . Adora sneered at the thought.

And now she could mostly read the weird rune-script. And hard wire the strange crystal electronics of the ancient precursors. No fancy weaponry, of course. Oh no, that was saved for *Swift Wind* it seemed.

Her mining, staying off the grid, it was all aimless. It kept her safe, yes, kept her away. She'd purged herself from the Imperial records

when she'd escaped the facility she'd been operating out of - well, mostly. You never *qite* vanished from the bureaucratic records of the Empire. But enough that tracking her was a headache - she was a ghost, an anomaly and, frankly, she hadnt gone on and made waves. And so she'd dropped down the priority list as she knew she would.

But out here she was able to go rooting through ruins, trying to piece together an understanding. t tickled her brain - her ship was *alien* now. Semi intelligent, maybe. And if she found artefacts that she could sell, then so much the better;some were good to help augment or reinforce aspects of *Swift Winds* core frameworks;the rest was jst useful jnk to be pawned of f.

And, well, it was like she felt drawn to know more. To understand the strange power her ship now possessed. That she possessed - after a fashion. t hadnt gifted her any new weapons, but it had amped up her already scary abilities.

She cursed again as a spark flickered through the wiring. She'd set up a small generator in the room, to power the lights and to help jmp start the local computers. A whirr , another spark and a load of holographic interfaces flickered to life around the small room. Adora crowed with triumph and then stood with a groan, stretching her limbs out.

She leaned over one and mumbled as she went through the records.

"Primary facility..yadda yadda..employment records…
Requisition orders..project.Eternia?..Huh. Warnings..critical
failure. No duh, planet blew up..Recommend transfer to Project
Etheria?..Ok, great, big ol'weapon. Where's the loot?"

She felt a little bad gracerobbing. But guaranteeing her safety and future wouldn't pay for itself.

She spasmed as a sense of *wrongness* washed over her. Something that felt like a blanket of oil, or like one of your senses being suddenly dampened. She tapped her comm as she tried to *think* at *Swift Wind* .

Nothing. Her eyes narrowed as she slowly moved to the doorway .

Silence reigned in the facility. Adora's eyes narrowed and she glanced around the room she was in. A dead end - some would say "great for last stands", but the reality was that all an attacker had to do was wait you out. Or gas you. Or, if they didn't care about casualties, fill it with enough High-Ex to turn you into liquid.

Relocate. Assess. Adapt.

She drew a deep breath - it could be a result of her activating the system;some dampening field perhaps?..She had just assumed this was a record room, it could also have been a security hub.

Adora reached down and unclipped the fastener on her holster. She wished she'd thought to bring the rifle in, but regret was a poor weapon on the battle field.

Adapt .

She made her way quietly out of the room, but left the lights and generator running. The background hum would draw any potential investigations *that* way - if she shut it off, that could tip off any *potential* hunters. Was she paranoid? Yes. Was she still alive? Also yes.

Adora made her way to the main control room, down several dark corridors - she'd spread her light stands out,like golden oases in the dark. She stepped over the scarab like husks of ancient defence drones, long since burned out and decayed, circled around cracked pillars, then emerged into the wide expanse. She hugged the walls and made her way to where she'd stored her cracking-equipment. A repurposed portable mining beam, along with some demo-charges.

She wasn't your typical archaeologist - sometimes doors needed to be unlocked and she had no time for the weird puzzle-oriented mentality of these ancient aliens. Yes, it was probably all part of a redundant security system for when they lost their ID cards or whatever, but frankly she preferred to punch her way through her problems.

Suitable up-armed, she touched the small computer on her wrist and brought up a basic holo-gram of the areas she'd explored. The tunnel to where she'd landed was a long line, with no real deviations, except to dead ends. That could buy her time. She hadn't set up sensors - mainly because they were expensive and, frankly , not that reliable. Their transmission range was awful and she'd have had to buy so many to spread them around the site, it wasn't worth it. So, she was blind. She did make a note to buy one for next time, even if to just leave it near an entrance so she'd have a good heads up.

Of course, *Swift Wind* should have noticed *something* and sent her an automated ping.

Which lent more credence to this being internal rather than external. Because finding this place was damn near impossible - she'd only found it due to all those *upgrades* to *Swift Wind's* systems - including a map of all facility sites that had handily been on one artefact she'd recovered.

Adora chewed her lip and huffed. She was about to move when a sound caught her ear - a click click of metal on stone.

Defence drones? She hadn't seen any active while being here? Again, was it the security systems coming back online?

She hefted the bulky mining beam - it looked like a cross between a flamer and some sort of squat lance. Not the best weapon, but it'd

suffice for now. And it had a good chance against dense material - like *metals* .

Carefully, Adora moved to cover behind a pillar and froze.

A pair of droids scuttled into the room. Horribly familiar and ugly in their brute efficiency - spherical, olive green and with a crimson central eye. Horde War-bots. Doctrine dictated they were sent as a forward force to trigger traps and act as remote warnings for the infantry. An oddly *caring* decision by Imperial Horde Command - spare the troops, use the bots. Of course it was couched in a doctrine of terror: you can't intimidate a bot and they were harder to kill. It just meant the infantry could get in quicker .

And the infantry was just there to soften things up for the *heavier* bots or elite troops anyway.

Adora pressed back against the pillar and took a slow, shallow breath - the bots were not *scout* probes - so their sensor suite was mostly heat and motion based - for easier target acquisition. Most of the bulk was for weapons and targeting in a battlefield, *not* easily identifying hidden targets - that was for the remote organic observers. Or a paired set of aerial drones with better sensors. And there wasn't exactly room for those in here.

A cold smile spread across her face as she realised.

This was an attempt to intimidate.

They saw her as a *miner* . They had Catra's intel on her and it seemed her old friend had a fairly low opinion of her. All they knew was she was ex-Horde, a cadet. With a fancy ship. It was a logical deduction. She doubted that they'd have handed out her *actual* service record - the bureaucracy in action again. And if they had? Well, she'd have to see what they sent in next. A reasonable deduction was that this was an attempt to flush her out - either so she capitulated, or so they could see what she did next.

They'd clearly neutralised *Swift Wind* somehow. That was troubling in itself - that they'd then come in for her led to more questions - if they just wanted the ship they would have left her here. But they wanted *her* as well. Maybe. Or maybe this was a kill team?

Too many questions. Adora gritted her teeth. She was still leaning towards this being a scare tactic. If they *knew* , well...they'd have probably just blown the corridor or flooded the place with a deadly neurotoxin.

Weaver AI's loved that last one.

She was banking on them *not* knowing. So, level the playing field, see what she was up against. Which meant luring in the actual troops.

Adora swung from behind the pillar and pressed the trigger. The mining beam flashed white hot and traced a line up a console, then bisected one of the droids. Both had turned as soon as she'd emerged. Adora moved quickly and rolled behind another console and a crimson blast split the air where she'd just been. She wasn't sure if that would have been a kill shot, but either way it'd have hurt if it'd connected.

The surviving droid was repositioning - she heard its metal limbs as they clattered on the tiles. Calmly, Adora propped the beam against a console, then aimed it at the apex of the main entry-way's arch. She flicked the switch and then set the catch that kept it depressed. It was a redundant feature for when you needed to mount the thing on a tripod, to let it burn through rock over a longer period of time.

She crawled away from the machine, using the consoles as cover, then rolled up and darted through the side entryway. Another laser punched through the air and burned a crips hole in the wall behind her. Adora swore and sped up.

Behind her she heard a crash as the mining laser successfully burned through the doorway's apex and brought the rubble down, blocking that exit. That'd buy her some time as they tried to navigate the side passages.

She hoped.

A horde team would not, *could not* capture her. The risk was too great. She was *not* going back. Even if she had to gut them all. Sweat beaded her forehead.

Not. Again.

Of course, if they had *Swift Wind* that was another issue. A very *very* dangerous issue. She cursed - she should have cut and run as soon as she'd seen Catra, as soon as she'd had to use the ship to fight off a horde Cruiser. Sentimental. Dangerous. Too many attachments.

She paused at a junction and hissed through her teeth, then punched the wall.

A voice echoed through the halls, amplified by echoing walls.

"Nice trick with the door…'Dor... but, really? Where you gonna go? We've got your ride. You played that hand and we've got bots to spare. Make it easy. We don't want to hurt you. Surrender. Give up. You've got form at that, after all. Take the easy way out. Trust me, you want to."

Adora gritted her teeth and twitched, "Catra," her hands balled into fists as a mix of emotions ran through her. Why, why did it have to be *her*. Catra..Catra had been *safe* after Adora left. After she complied. And then when she *left*.

And now here she was. Adora turned and rested the back of her head against the cool stone of the wall. She gazed at the faded murals, the thin white, glowing lines of yet another pictogram - people bowing at another figure. Another showing a sun consuming worlds. Another showing a vast pit and hands reaching up.

Lost mythology, meaningless. No grand weapons, no blade of destiny to strike down evil. No easy way out.

Just her and the dark.

She could do it. Probably. But there was only *one* corridor out. If Catra was any good (And she was, Adora had to admit that - she'd kept up with some of Catra's escapades whilst still *serving*, bad and good), then she'd have a layered defence at the exit. Adora would have to fight her way up the corridor, then climb a rope up to the surface, *then* face whatever was at the landing area.

Too many variables, not enough intel. She had the layout, but the place was linear, confined and, frankly, a series of killzones. Her weapons were limited and while she *could* retrieve armaments from her enemies as soon as she showed her true colours, well, she was damn sure Catra *would* blow the tunnel and deal with her later once she'd brought in bigger guns.

So, option A was a bust. Option B, straight surrender? Something about that felt off. Catra would suspect a ruse. She was almost as

paranoid as Adora. Scans, restraints, everything. She'd be on edge.

Option C - make it *look good* .

Adora could definitely do that.

Catra stood, arms crossed, next to the disappointingly mundane-looking mining rig. *Swift Wind* didn't look like it lived up to the moniker - all squat metal and arrow-head shape. She had seen what it could do, though. Something about it made her shiver - it had a sense of *potential* to it. Like it would stand up and start killing by itself.

Which was impossible. AIhoused in fighters were notoriously unreliable. It's why Weaver's needed a core and a ship and *so many restraining protocols* even on normal ships.

"Whoo I am RELEVED that worked!" Entrapta's bubbly voice jarred Catra from her musings and she quirked an eyebrow .

"You mean you weren't *sure?"*

"Never tested it in a live environment. But the principle was sound! Wavelengths, projected, cancel each other out, feedback loops, and a good ECM and dampening field and wooop, instant tranquiliser ."

Catra's mouth twisted and her tail lashed from side to side, "You make it sound alive."

"Well, it is sort of. The pulse is just that, a *pulse* . I mean, well, not *alive* , but complex enough to be comparable? I don't think the ship is, well, *sapient* . But without the power core any security protocols and redundant features shouldn't activate."

"So it still could?"

"MAYBE!" Entrapte grinned wildly . Around them troops were moving more bots from the troop carrier. Two had descended down the pit already, with a squad behind them. Another set of troops were moving to establish the first fallback point and defence line. Part of Catra had wanted to waive that and just send in a squad to knock the idiot out. But another part of her wanted to be *sure* .

They had no intel on the interior and she remembered Adora had always been scrappy in training. A life on the rim had probably hardened her to be at least moderately competent - after all, she *had* taken Catra's ship down with ease. Mostly due to her ship, but Catra had underestimated the woman once before. Twice would be stupid. Better to be cautious and sure.

She gazed at the ship again and shuddered, "Just keep it sedated or whatever. Any chance you can get inside?"

"Ummm. I'd rather do *that* in a secure environment. We don't know if Adora has any specific traps set up. I can't get a reading on the interior, just the energy emissions."

"Right. Dead man's switches, bio locks, that sorta stuff, right?"

"EXACTLY!"

"So, we may need Adora to pop the hood. Get it. Well, once we've got her, plus some bio samples, we'll haul this to the base and… Send Adora on her way," Catra's mouth twisted at that. She had the ship. Part of her wanted to keep Adora. But another part, a guilty part, filled with the memory of Adora's face as she was whipped to within an inch of her life - that part wanted to take Adora to a transit hub and just let her disappear into the endless sea of citizenry - to be safe.

After all, Adora *had* spared her life. And keeping her away from Imperial Horde Intelligence was a mercy. They had the ship - they didn't need to hand Adora over into the bargain. She'd claim the girl had escaped or had died in transit and they had enough bio samples, should they be needed. Hopefully Adora was savvy enough to just hand the proverbial keys over and then ghost. Just like before.

Nearby two of her tech-crew had set up a mini command node and were manning the comms. One glanced at Catra and beckoned her over. Catra spun from the mining-rig and stalked across the cavern. She spared her landing ship a glance as more troops filed from it. No kill like *overkill* .

"Report."

"Contact about five hundred metres inside. One bot down."

Catra quirked an eyebrow , "What? She leave a booze bottle lying around?"

"Uh..she cut it in half with a mining laser ."

Catra blinked, "Huh. The other one get her?"

"Uh...no ma'am. She blew the doorway and seems to have withdrawn into the complex. Our sonar scanners and laser mapping..it..cant penetrate the substructure of the complex beyond a few metres. She could be anywhere down there."

With a sigh Catra massaged the bridge of her nose, "So, get more bots in there."

"W e uh..we could just blow the doors, leave her down there?" piped up the other tech, "She may have supplies, but...unlikely she has another way off this rock."

"And then what, genius?" harrumphed Catra, "W e dont know if we need her *alive* to open this thing up. And if blowing this vents atmosphere down there. Or maybe she *does* have access to *another* weird alien vessel. G ds, you guys are never gonna make of ficer if you take *easy* options. We need her *alive* ."

hside her heart had begun to hammer - the idea of leaving Adora alone in the dark carried a strange feeling in her gut. Catra had been put into isolation in boot camp, when they were *very* young. A dark hole. No light. No sounds. For two days.

But Adora had snuck in, cracked the hatch and dropped a ration bar in, then whispered the words *I'll be here. I'll wait.* The idea of being stuck in the dark..terrified Catra. So to do that to Adora? Another twinge of betrayal in her mind. Yeah, the blonde *had* left her in the end. But there were some lines..she'd let Adora go and they'd be sqare after this. She *wouldn't* trap her in a dark, desolate mae. But she *did* need to catch her.

"G e me the comm," Catra reached for the hand-set as the tech nodded. She snatched it up and a mirthless smile crossed her face, "Alright Adora..you wanna play , let's play."

Chapter End Notes

Lots of back and forth in terms of timeline. Are our misguided former besties gonna have a heart to heart soon? YOU KNOW IT.

Giving you some insights into their backstory here. And Adora's. Which well get a LOT more of this episode / story. And expand upon...

Also, spot the references!

Dancing in the dark

Chapter Summary

Plans are made in ignorance by the rebels;worries are voiced by friends.

And in the ruins, a pair of lost souls cross paths once more.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

36 hours prior

"Brightmoon command to *Sea Gate* , switch to band Theta 3.2."

"Acknowledged Brightmoon command, switching."

"Mermista, Juliet here. We've got a report confirmation, suspected Horde resupply convoy . Transmitting the co-ordinated route."

"Thanks Jules. So, like, can we expect support from her psychoticness this time?"

In the command room of the Rebel safe-harbour , Juliet smirked. A few of the crew around her, manning their duty stations exchanged nervous but amused glances. The head of security huffed, "Nah,

she's off on one of her mining trips. And, well, you didnt complain a week ago after that brush with the Waster-remnant."

"Ugh. We totally had them. But, yeah. She was useful. Just, not so much when she nearly breaks arms on OUR team."

"Well, Huntara shouldnt have tried to argue about her Horde jacket…or so Angella says. Not sure what the big freakin' deal is," Juliet groused. She kept her voice relatively low on that last point.

"Like, fine. Well, we'll review. Uhhh… Sea Hawk is gonna sit this one out. Can you, like, get him a nice cosy milk run? He's NAGGING me that these are, like, a trap. Or too easy."

Juliet pursed her lips and snorted, "We're on the fringes. The Horde doesnt *care*. They're probably writing these losses off as *acceptable*. And hey, we left the last four alone"…

"That's what I said! Anyway, I'll buy you a beer next time we're in, reckon we can turn a profit if these manifests are right."

"Sounds good, Captain. Though Casta may have words if we get too rowdy!"

“ *Not Glim? She’s nearly as scary as tall-blonde-and-nutty. If you mess her bar up…”*

“Yeah, just… if Sea Hawk isn’t there to set a fire.”

“Fair. We’ll keep it cool. Say hi to Casta for me. And uh… just… if you can get Adora on the comm, just in case. Not saying Sea Hawk’s right, but y’know.”

“Yeah yeah. Well, we have *other* assets. We don’t need to call her for *everything* ,” snorted Juliet. Around her the other crew were a mix of expressions. Some nodded decisively . Others looked distinctly uneasy. Juliet leaned back in her seat, which was set at one of the monitor banks. All around, the crew stood or sat near terminals or computer frames, checking readouts. She signed off with Mermista then stood and stretched.

“Ma’am?” a sensor tech glanced up at her , “Got some sensor ghosts near the planetoid… the debris field, I mean.”

Juliet’s eyes narrowed, “Clarify?”

“Just… for a moment there was something there. That was the slated location that uh… Adora gave us. To send any band comms?”

Juliet's forehead creased in a frown, "Anything else?"

"No"…

"Well, it's a debris cloud. And the Horde stealth tech isn't *that* fancy. Not that they'd bother with here. It's just Adora and her mining rig there"…

"Her stupidly powerful mining rig" muttered one crewman. Juliet shot him a look and he glanced away. Juliet turned back to the sensor tech and chewed her lip.

"Alright. Keep an eye. Narrow band comms if you don't hear anything from our wild card."

The tech nodded. Then a siren blared and another station reported in, "Horde frigate, belt periphery! Heading for one of the mining teams,"

Juliet sighed, the sensor ghost forgotten in the light of a *substantial* problem, "Just get them to go low power, send a wing out, harry them for a bit, draw them off. Make sure the fighters have pirate markings, ok?"

"Roger , ma'am."

The crew refocused on their duties, the hum drum of running a backwater operation sliding back into place. The Sensor tech made a note to comm Adora on a pad, then promptly forgot about it. After all, the woman looked after herself.

Down in the bar, Bow leaned against a table and rolled a glass between his fingers. He heaved a sigh, then looked up at his wife, who had him fixed with a bemused frown. He adjusted himself on his seat and shrugged, "What?"

"You're thinking."

"Well.yes," he managed, then reached up to scratch the back of his neck, "Just.got a really bad feeling."

Glimmer , sat opposite him, leaned forwards. The bar was quiet - DT was in his shop, the regulars were out doing their *actual* job of mining. Perfuma was down in hydroponics. It was definitely quiet time. The pink haired woman cocked her head to one side, "What about?"

"Not sure. Adora.well she said she had an errand."

"You're still worried she won't tell us what she's doing?"

"I mean, I get the trauma. The trust, right? But... I don't know. I feel there's *something* else."

"We can only listen, babe. And, hey, you *know* how I'm climbing the walls wanting to know her whole... thing. But we're getting there. We've gone a couple of weeks with no violent altercations!"

"Huntara..."

"...brought it on herself trying to start shit in the bar. Adora was actually *playing cards*. I mean actually *socialising*. She even *laughed* at one of Perfuma's jokes."

"Except Perfuma wasn't making a joke." Bow arched an eyebrow. Glimmer waved him off.

"Not the point! We were breaking down walls! So... she's just gone to clear her head. She does that. And anyway, horde activity has dropped, pirate activity is non existent, we're getting actual *traders* coming through. I know I'm the cynic and you're the optimist... and for once I'M optimistic! Don't get all grumpsy on me!"

Bow chuckled, "Grumpsy? Really Grumpsy?"

"Is that *any* worse than the crap you come up with?" she smiled fondly at him, "Now, don't gripe. Go rewire a fluxpipe or something. That always cheers you up."

"Fluxpipes are for plasma... putting an electrical current..."…

"LALALALA! TECH STUFF DON'T CARE!" Glimmer stood and yanked her husband out of his chair, "Go tackle the cable snarls you hate so much. And Adora is *more* than capable of looking after herself. She's just gone to do some mining. She'll be back before you know it. I'm sure she's just, yknow... meditating or whatever it is Imperial Assassins on the run do when they're smashing rocks for credits do."

"Yeah," Bow smiled, "You're probably right."

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31 hours prior

A laser bolt sliced through the top of the cover Adora was crouched behind. Her face was set in a determined line as she counted down from eight. Then she pressed the button on the detonator clasped in her hand. Beyond the cover, a series of *whump whump whumps* sounded and dust cascaded up and around, followed by the

electrical whine of droids and the echoing clang of metal being bounced around stone.

Without waiting for a response, Adora dashed from cover and into one of the many rooms that branched off from the corridor. She had to relocate - the droids had bypassed two of her other routes and now she had to lure any others into the non-compromised corridors. t'd gone this way for the last few hours since Catra' s mocking challenge.

So far it had just been bots - no soldiers. She'd had to duck and dive in one wide room, luring a couple of droids under a weakened pillar where she'd crushed them. Then she'd managed to repurpose one of the bot's laser cannons into a rudimentary static defence point, where it'd taken out the follow up droids. W ell, *one* of them. Catra had had the others hose the room with laser fire.

Adora had fallen back, then moved to an adjacent corridor , lured more bots down it and blown a few set charges. She'd dropped onto another droid with a piece of sharpened metal and speared the thing.in another corridor and then withdrawn again.

She'd collapsed tunnels, managed to get a couple of bots trying to flank her to take each other out.

Though she always made sure to be *seen* by the bots. That wasnt hard or even really avoidable - the confines of the place meant she was, actually, just dodging them. But she'd had time to at least set

traps, so she wasn't having to do that in tandem with running. Catra had moved fast, she'd give the woman that. But *not* fast enough. Of course, all of her traps being mining charges and weakened rubble, it didn't SEEM prepped - just desperate, opportunistic. Hell, she even had made it look like she'd been winged by a droid.

Adora scoffed at that as she clutched the cauterised burn on her arm. Yeah, *made it look like* .

She was losing her touch. Or rather, she didn't want to rely on her *other* skills. As soon as she did that, well... The gloves might come off for Catra. But was she being paranoid? Would they even be able to *tell* ?

She leaned back against a cold, grey-blue wall, the darkness around her all encompassing. It was a moment of respite, though her heart hammered and her mind raced. So many conflicting thoughts vied for her attention - the ever present whisper of the conditioning, barely suppressed, demanding she surrender, or kill, or surrender *then* kill; the voices of her... her *friends* as they joked over cards or a drink, as her walls had slowly come down - as they'd wished her *safe flight* before she'd left on this errand. Bow's infectious grin and Glimmer's eye roll. Even Juliet had given her a curt wave. Though that *could* have been her giving Adora the finger. Too far to tell.

Slowly, so slowly, Brightmoon had felt *close* to feeling like a safe haven.

This little strike by Catra had dashed that. After this she'd have to move on. Again. Run. Again. Leave.

Again.

t made her gut coil. Her anger spike.

But she tamped down on it. Anger made you make mistakes. t made you misread the battlefield. t made you overcommit. t was useful in a brawl, in the thick of it. But not when you needed to *plan* .

But what *was* the plan? Get captured, yes, but then? Fight it out on better terrain? Escape? What was the endgame?

Adora drew a halting breath winced at the pain in her arm. Pain was pain - even with her various *perks* healing took time and energy. Energy she couldn't easily spare right now . But it helped her focus.

Kill Catra? That thought stuck like a bone in her throat and made bile rise. Could she, if push came to shove? Honestly?

t wasn't something she had *really* thought about. Twice, at least, she'd come close. The ship, when it was crippled; the panet, her rifle readied. But she hadn't committed. n the past, with others, she hadn't even hesitated.

So, why now? Why hadn't she formulated a plan to lure the troopers in, to dispatch them, then advance up that tunnel to gut the woman who had... had...

Adora squeezed her eyes shut. The strange twinge at hearing the woman's voice - the roiling anger and guilt and almost *happiness* that those husky sounds brought up in her. Was that was this was? Did she just want to *talk* to the woman? The woman she'd desperately wanted to drag away from the horde?

The one she'd been... she'd tried thinking of a future with? Back then the idea had been nebulous - just a desire to be *free* and *together*. Youthful naivete maybe. But there was something else behind it, something Adora didn't have a name for. Or wouldn't name. Because to do so would unleash the bile of hate and despair.

But, by the gods... she wanted to see her. After that, Adora wasn't sure - she might just strangle her.

She chuckled darkly and grit her teeth - that was unlikely. She knew herself well enough - it'd take a *lot* to run Catra through.

The sound of metal on stone roused her and she sighed - she was running out of rooms and bolt holes. Each ambush cut off an avenue; made it too hard to backtrack down with rubble or the risk of further cave ins. She'd mapped out her retreat as best she could, but she was at a dead end now. One last series of rooms.

She sqinted into the dark as she heart a dif ferent sound - boots. Faint, yes, but definitely there. Catra had committed her infantry.

The smile that split Adora’s face was cold, mirthless.

t was time to end this.

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t was *not* going as easily as Catra had expected. Honestly , she wasnt sure *what* she’d expected. Adora had proven capable in space - but Catra had put that down to the *ship* . Mostly. She didnt want to consider that, maybe, Adora had been competent enough to outfly her. Though it had been the case back at the Academy, it had been years. But, clearly, the frontier had given the wash-out the chance to hone some skills.

This little game of cat and blonde-mouse had shown that Adora was scrappy, though. Catra recognised the escape and evasion tactics drilled into them. They were sloppy, desperate and doomed, however. The droids had, as they’d advanced, managed to get some solid echo-mapping of the base. And, if what her techs were telling her was accurate, Adora was fighting a losing war, backing herself into a corner.

There was the likelihood of a back door, obviously. Except, if such a thing existed, why hadn't Adora just blown the tunnels and fled? No - the fact she was fighting at all showed she had no-where to go. This was desperate bravado. She was scared of the retribution Catra was going to bring.

But Catra wasn't *malicious* . That thought made the feline chuckle to herself. Ok, she was a little. But Adora had shown spunk. Shown she wasn't a complete coward, that she was capable of *development* . It made her feel a little bit weird, though. She had intended to let her go, partly as a sort of returning-the-favour for sparing Catra's life and the lives of her crew. But now? Now it was also, or would be, a sign of grudging respect.

"Ma'am, we've lost...bots eight and ten."

"What was it this time?" Catra sighed.

"Uh...clearance charges, we think."

She didn't rig another laser trap?"

"No...another corridor ."

"Bring the map up." She leaned forwards and peered at the portable terminal. The red areas delineated denied routes. There was now a single route that led into a series of only vaguely defined rooms. Catra snorted, "A www.cute. She's set up a single route into a kill zone. Or tried to. Get the ground-pounders up behind the last bots. You did hold the *armoured* bots in reserve, right?"

"Y ...yes ma'am," stuttered the tech. Catra patted him on the shoulder.

"Good. Well done. After this, you boys have earned some down time planetside."

"Thank you ma'am!" The two techs exchanged a grin - time out of a ship and away from recycled air was *bliss*. For her part, Catra just suppressed a snort. Carrot and stick - and the carrot was ridiculously easy. The Horde leaned more towards the stick method, so much so that even a simple gesture got you stupid amounts of cautious goodwill.

Of course there was still *risk* with that - the crew could get *entitled*. Or they got lazy. So far, the fact that she wasnt *Octavia* seemed enough for most of the troopers and their commanders. Oh, sure, the homicidal AIthat could vent their ships was another point in Catra's favour - the proverbial stick she held over their heads. But the simple luxuries and freedoms she provided allowed them to ignore that.

"I'm gonna join them," mused the cat-woman, "Command this one… personally."

"Uh, you sure ma'am?" the two troopers exchanged another , more worried glance, "if we wait, she could entrench herself."

"Get the grunts into the first chamber , suppression fire to keep her on her toes. But I want to watch her go down, face to face."

"By your command, ma'am."

Catra's grin was feral as she ploined into the ruined depths. She nearly laughed, heart pounding with something akin to anticipation and eagerness? She wasn't quite sure what she was eager to see? The woman who had humiliated her brought low? The woman she hadn't seen for years? The woman she'd last seen being… brought low.

She slowed in a dark, isolated corridor, cleared by her troops of mechanical debris and stared at nothing. Her tail flicked from side to side. Slowly, she swallowed and leaned against a cold wall as bile rose in her gut. A sense of odd de ja vu whirled in her head.

"No, no, this, this is just the mission. And, well, I'm *saving* her. She's just making this hard. If she just, if she'd just *surrendered*."… Catra grit her teeth and her face slid into a snarl. She dropped to all fours and sprinted down the corridor, vaulting rubble and cleared bots, the wreckage pushed to the side by her troops.

She reached the rearguard swiftly - their advance had been slower as they'd double checked for follow on booby traps that maybe the bots wouldnt have triggered. A Force-Corporal saluted her and pointed into the dimly lit interior of the room beyond the corridor - blue-white lines of light cast shadows across a pillared expanse. Red beams lanced from a pair of more heavily armoured bots that were advancing in a split formation across the room. At the far end was another door. Catra knew it led into a likely dead end.

"We've got her pinned. She's using some old debris and supply crates as cover. Works against her though, ma'am. Her line of sight is limited to the central avenue of the room - the pillars conceal the flanks. But we reckon, if her prior actions are any indicator, she'll have set traps."

"Did she have time," mused Cata.

"We would rather not risk it... She managed to wing Raksha and Gunrig. Philto is bunkered down further in, bleeding out." the Force-Corporal venture. Catra nodded slowly, then indicated a couple of busted up droids they had in reserve, as well as a couple of troopers sheltering in the door frame, nursing blast wounds on their armour - they looked like non fatal wounds at least. She could make out a third in the room - some idiot had probably tried to get a closer look, or a stealthy advance and Adora had taken a shot. He looked to be moving, mostly in pain - a gut shot maybe?

"Send the other down the flanks, keep the pressure on. Riot shields?"

"Y esm."

Get them up. f those shots are any indicator , the girl's only got a side arm. And the bots will keep her suppressed. ave a sharpshooter here, to keep her pinned as well."

"Y esm," the Force-Corporal turned and barked a few orders into his comm - the troops split into three groups, four of them hefting large, bulky shields in front of them. The others drew stun-batons and side arms. Catra hissed.

"W e need her alive. No firearms. Suppressive fire only. Your sharpshooter is *only* to fire on her if the shot will *wound* only. She dies, we might not be able to use that hunk of metal up there."

She didnt say what else bubbled up - that whoever *killed* Adora would likely have their throat carved out. She wasnt sure where that came from - latent guilt? A relic of their friendship? Or was it really her mission driving it?

The Force-Corporal nodded, then turned to the men, who were already holstering their sidearms. The rear guard had their rifles in low-port, save the sharpshooter, who was taking aim and snapping off shots to keep the distant figure of Adora in cover.

Slowly, the men advanced, whilst the droids scurried off to either flank. Catra grinned, then looked up at the pillars. To her side, the Force-Corporal coughed and asked, "Ma'am? Anything else?"

"Keep her focused. I'll go high."

And with that she darted into the shadows near the door and leapt towards a pillar. Her claws sunk in as she scrambled up the smooth stone. At its apex, where it met the ceiling, she watched as one of the flanking droids vanished in a sudden gout of dust and rubble - a proximity charge. The other advanced unscathed, whilst the troopers in the centre paused at the sound of the explosion. From here, Catra could just make out a blonde head as it popped up to squeeze a couple of shots off. They bounced, harmlessly, from the riot shields held by the soldiers. Adora was forced to duck down as a laser bolt pinged off the stone near her, and Catra used that moment to leap to the next pillar. Her claws sunk in and she slid down only a couple of feet. She repeated this as her men slowly advanced.

Adora seemed to be getting desperate, her shots going wild. Catra tensed, nearly at the pillar near to Adora's cover, ready to drop down. She watched, waiting for Adora to sprint for the final doorway.

But the blonde fired a couple more shots and then cursed. Her pistol whined - a sound that indicated a depleted charge.

The blonde cursed, then hefted a mining tool - a pickaxe - and vaulted her cover and *charged.*

Catra was dumbfounded. The sharpshooter tried to fire, but his shot was obscured by the horde troopers who had nearly closed on Adora's cover. The flanking droid and the armoured units couldn't get a firing solution because Adora was *there* , in the middle of the men. Catra stared as Adora shoulder barged into a riot-shield and drove the man backwards. She watched the trooper fall and her jaw dropped as the blonde followed up with a stumbling lunge at an unshielded soldier.

The man raised his shock-baton in a desperate parry, but the pickaxe knocked it aside. Adora brought the makeshift weapon around and cracked the man in his armoured chest with a clang. The trooper went down with a grunt.

Adora was clearly a brawler. Bar fights? Mining claims gone bad? Catra wasn't sure. Either way , her men weren't any slouches themselves, but they clearly hadn't been expecting *this.*

The other shield troops were trying to box her in, but one stumbled away as Adora used her pickaxe to grapple the shield' s edge and haul the man forward. She then tripped him and went to tackle another soldier.

She clearly had no strategy - just targets of opportunity . Catra watched as a strike from a baton sent Adora staggering, causing the blonde to swipe out wildly. Another made her scream out and the noise made Catra's blood chill. But then Adora lurched forwards and cracked a man's wrist with a downward swipe. She stomped to one

side and Catra heard the crack of someone's knee being re-arranged, followed by the howl of a trooper.

That seemed to change things. As one the troopers charged in, batons swinging, electrical charges firing. Adora cracked one man in the face plate with the butt of the pickaxe, then embedded the tip into the shoulder of another man, before three batons jammed into her at the same moment. She howled and sank to a knee, then vainly powered forwards, desperate, as she tackled a man to the ground, pushing him clear of the scrum and bowling a few other men over. She was wrestling him for his baton, her body bleeding from scrapes and burns. She'd clearly been hit more than Catra realised.

As the troops made to move again, Catra made her move. She vaulted from the pillar and landed between the troops and the struggling Adora. In a swift motion she had unhooked her own baton, then reached forwards and yanked Adora's long blonde hair back. The woman yelped and tried to twist.

As she did so, Catra delivered a kick to Adora's kidney. It made the blonde double over and roll. To the woman's credit, she tried to stand up, but Catra delivered another kick across her face that sent her rolling over the floor. Adora lay still for a moment as Catra advanced. The soldiers moved to surround her, batons raised.

Slowly, Adora put her hands onto the stone floor and tried to get up. Her head rose and Catra stopped in her advance as blue eyes regarded her.

They seemed so full of… *something* . Catra couldn't tell what. And that scared her. She used to be able to read Adora like a book. Her face had always been so open, so expressive, her eyes an open window into her mind.

These eyes… they scared her . And she had no idea *why* .

So she did what she always did when faced with something intimidating - she went for breezy condescension.

"Heyyyy Adora. No need to get up."

Adora stared at her and something familiar flickered onto her face. It was almost a smile. An expression of fondness? But it vanished quickly . The woman let out a pained breath, "Is… is that what your bosses say while you're licking their boots?"

Catra's stomach tightened and she let out a low growl, "I'm not the one kneeling in their own blood right now, am I Adora? Credit where it's due, you put up a good fight. No idea why though. I mean… we got what we needed. You could have done this the easy way, but oh no… Adora just has to be the big shot. Martyr . What, you were hoping to die in some grand last stand?"

Adora coughed again and tried to rise, but a trooper stepped forwards and jammed a baton between her shoulder blades. She convulsed and sagged to the floor again. Catra bit back the rebuke

she'd been about to deliver to the soldier. That wouldn't look good. The blonde groaned and lolled her head to one side. A single blue eye peered up at her through lank strands of blonde hair, "Well done Catra. Get everyone else to do your dirty work. Not changed then"…

Catra's lips formed into a thin line. She jutted her chin forwards, "Take her away. And *no* roughing her up, understood? She...she fought well. Any more bruises on her and I'll *know*."

The soldiers exchanged glances, their visors concealing their expressions, but they moved to obey. A pair shackled Adora's hands behind her back, then her ankles, before they hauled her to her feet and dragged her from the room.

Catra stood as the troopers and bots began to exit, a few milling about to police the remaining salvage and mining equipment. She looked around the strange, blue-lit room; she took in the strange murals of swords and heroes; of stylised beings and strange constellations. She felt her hands clench and unclench, whilst her tail lashed from side to side.

"Is this winning?" she mused. Her jaw twisted as she looked down at where Adora had fallen. *It doesn't feel like it.* The thought felt treacherous.

But then she hadn't won *yet.* She still had the system to pacify. The ship to unravel. And, well...she had to let Adora go. Then, maybe… then she'd feel like she'd won.

That was it.

With a hiss that startled the nearby troops, she spun on her heel and stalked from the chamber.

Chapter End Notes

> Yeah not like these two have any unresolved issues AT ALL. NUHUH
>
> Wonder how that friendly chat will go, face to face...

In the house...

Chapter Summary

Adora is captured!

Sea Hawk does something MAD!

Adora.... is clearly entirely at the Horde's mercy!

Chapter Notes

HOO EEEE!

It's a long one. And yeah, Catra WOULD win this, if only Adora wasn't a FREAKING UNPREDICT ABLE ASSHOLE.

Who am I kidding, Adora is clearly out of the game.

Oh and yes, chapter extension. AS you can see, a lot to get through.

Next chapter will likely be a little shorter to close things out as we escalate...

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Sea Hawk! Do NOT! I REPEAT! DO NOT Engage…" the radio crackled briefly, *"Please…."*

The moustachioed privateer closed his eyes and exhaled, then flicked the *off* switch on his comm unit. Ahead, through the canopy of his souped up shuttle, the bulk of the Imperial Horde Destroyer loomed. Its bow was coming about, ready to line up another kill shot on the near-crippled pirate cruiser.

He knew his allies would usher the freighters away - this whole raid was a bust. But it would be a horrific loss if the *Sea Gate* was destroyed.

Sacrifice a pawn to save a Queen - he smiled ruefully to himself, remembering a lesson that Mermista's father had bestowed upon him, many moons ago. He knew the man had tolerated him, but had a strange fondness as well. Likely because, at the heart of it all, he knew that Sea Hawk had one main overriding priority that superseded absolutely everything, common sense be damned.

"Be safe, my love," he murmured, then grasped the control yoke and spun his ship into a barrel roll. Red bolts and beams lanced by, through the cold void. He surged between them, dancing between the shots. He was an artist, space his canvas and he painted a picture swirling patterns as he surged ahead. The horde gunners seemed to be erratic, unused to such a jinking target - no doubt more experienced with trading blows with enemy capital ships, or the more poorly trained smugglers and pirates. Perhaps the core worlds were too pacified to not offer decent challenges. Or perhaps he had them rattled.

A man could dream, right?

He crowed with joy as he spun his vessel, thrusters causing it to coast at an angle, momentum flinging it sideways. The enemy gunners, caught off guard by his trajectory, led in the wrong direction and most of the shots went far wide. He blasted his main engine and

rocketed forwards, down the flank of the destroyer, then flicked a switch open the shuttle's cargo hatch. There was the sound of venting atmosphere and the rattle of cargo being discharged.

The next turn pushed him back into his seat as he banked hard and skimmed low over the upper deck of the destroyer, too close for point defence to track. More cargo rattle free, the crates bursting behind his vessel as the timed charges on them exploded. He cleared the bow, just above the main aperture of the spinal cannon, then did a 180.

A grin split his face as he surveyed his handiwork - a cloud of mineral dust and scrap metal blossomed across the surface of the destroyer, caught within the pull of its shields - the junk having emerged too slowly and too close to the gargantuan ship. The turrets swivelled blindly across the flank of the vessel facing the *Sea Gate* , their sensors blinded by myriad obstacles, dust and radiation. The vessel was still turning, slowly, but inexorably , but now unable to pour on broadside fire at least.

"And here we go."

With a whine of strained engines, he gunned the shuttle forwards, aiming down the throat of the beast.

"What do you mean *no firing solutions*?" hissed Catra from the command chair. Their victory was at hand - the only major naval threat within the sector on deaths door and now they were blind? "I can see the damn ship FINE!"

"Uh..it's the gunnery teams ma'am - their targeting systems aren't allowing them to fire - debris field and..."..

"Then fuckin' *eyeball* the shots! It's a fuckin' *Cruiser*!"

"At five hundred K, ma'am?" the gunnery officer turned at their station - some replacement staff, as she'd entrusted Lonnie and Kyle with her more *important* mission. Not that this objective wasn't important. But the other one was...More vital. To her. A debt owed. And she couldn't be seen doing it herself.

Scorpia, standing to one side of the chair, hummed in a conciliatory way, "We've um, we've almost got the main gun to bear ma'am."

"Uhhh," Rogelio turned at the helm and hissed out a query. The translators kicked in a second later, "*Shuttle on collision course."*

"That...yahoo?" snarled Catra, "Idiot has...stones. Shoot it down."

The gunnery officer growled and turned again, "Point defence can't get a bead, he's...jinky."

"For the love of stars, what am I *paying* you guys for? Earn your keep, give me solutions. Oh, here's one. FIRE THE BLOODY FUCKING GUN!"

The crew flinched and the gunnery officer managed to get in a question, "The main gun on a shuttle, but it'll need to charge and…"

"And if the shuttle you can't shoot down hits it?" Catra stood from her chair, "Did. I Stutter? Fire the fuckin' GUN!"

"Uh Wildcat, you, you ok?"

Catra swivelled and glared at Scorpia, "I am *fine* Commander. Did you have a *point*?" So what if she felt edgy. So what if their chat in the brig hadn't gone down as well as she'd hoped. So what if the lump in her throat wouldn't fucking *move*? No, she was going to win. She was going to pacify this damn system and she was going to pay back her debt and keep Adora safe and she was going to hand that damn alien tech *thing* over and retire somewhere with a hot sun and servants and no *reminders* …

Scorpia swallowed at the steely glare from her Captain. The feline officer's hair was pulled back over her ears, her cloak wrapped tightly over her shoulders. She took an immediate executive decision and looked at the gunnery officer, "Fire the damn gun, you heard the Captain!"

Sea Hawk yelped as he saw the red glow building in the barrel of the massive weapon ahead of him. His computer helpfully announced: *“Plasma discharge - imminent!”*

“Oh Holly good!” he squeaked, then spun his shuttle just as a vibrant, searing white beam shot forth. The interior of the shuttle heated by several degrees and he felt his hairs singe from the transfer, but the beam missed by a hairs breadth - he angled his trajectory - no main gun for him today..but he still had one target of opportunity . He adjusted and gunned the afterburners.

Rogelio snarled, *“Shuttle on course correction… for the bridge!”*

Catra yowled in frustration. She pounced from her chair and shoved the gunnery officer to one side. Her claws flew over the console and she brought up manual control of one of the closer point defence turrets. She shrieked in rage as she hammered the fire button, manually adjusting the firing arc as she did so, “FUCK YOU!”

Red bolts lanced out seared into the shuttle's armour Sea Hawk cursed, jolted and grappled the controls. He heard something disconnect and the atmosphere began to vent;ahead, the view yawed to one side as his engines failed. He groaned and hauled on the yoke to try and keep the shuttle on course, but shots punched into his craft as it tumbled away. The venting atmosphere sent him into a pinwheel. And then something caught a spark. Sea Hawk swore and scrambled for a release hatch.

The world went white.

Catra panted hard and leaned on the console. She slowly turned and fixed her two-toned gaze on the stunned Gunnery Officer, "Sort. Yourself. Out. I will *not* do every damn job on this ship. If you can't do it, I will replace you. *Everyone* is replaceable."

She pushed away from the terminal and stalked back to her seat. Scorpia coughed and glared at the gunnery officer, who scurried back to her post with a chagrined expression her face. The XO glanced down at her commanding officer, then back across the bridge, "Update?"

" *Ten seconds until enemy vessel is in firing arc. Forward batteries should be able to engage until primary gun can fire again,"* reported Rogelio.

"Ma'am, new sensor contact. Unidentified Frigate, bearing..." the nav-officer rattled off a number and frowned, "It's the *Revenge*?"

Catra sat up, "I sent them on a...Courier job. They can't be... Weaver, why didn't you alert me?"

The AI's voice seemed perturbed, "Catra, the *Revenge* is currently heading to the system's edge. My sub-clone's records and transmissions show this"...

"Then why is it coming out of warp *here*?"

"Well, maybe your organic systems are *wrong*. Wouldn't be the first time"...

The nav officer huffed, "Well, this imaginary shipp is coming in hot... By the Emperor," he blinked in surprise, all four eyes agog, "Red shift...they've just pulled out of warp at...oh no...BRACE BRACE BRACE!"

The unidentified frigate appeared in a flash of purple and blue wisps of light and matter, engines at full burn. Rogelio swore and adjusted course, the massive destroyer adjusting its bow to dip. The frigate barrelled across their arc, its underside venting atmosphere and flames. There was the screech of metal on metal as shields flared. The frigate continued on and the shocked bridge crew watched as it

soared ahead. Its course seemed to adjust and it angled up and to its flank.

"It's... it's heading for the *Ravager*!" shouted the nav officer. He slammed the comm switch, "*Ravager,* take emergency mano-"

Too late. The careening frigate smashed into the *Ravager* at beyond-recommended speed. There was a white flash and both ships vanished from existence. Scorpia swallowed, "Did... did it trigger its warp core... how? That's suicide?"

"Weaver!" shouted Catra.

"I don't," the AI sounded actually *distressed*, "It's at the system's edge. But... wait... these packets... no. no. I cannot. I CANNOT BE HACKED!? No!"

Catra stared at the speaker, dumbfounded, then at Scorpia, then back at the speaker. She then looked at the crew, then out the view-screen. Ahead, the *Sea Gate* loomed, just outside of their firing arc, "Adjust... we can figure this out after..."

With a flash and a burst of flame and shedding armour, the *Sea Gate* vanished into warp. Catra's claws bit into the arm rests of her chair. Scorpia took a step away. The Nav and Gunnery officers exchanged a nervous glance. Slowly, Catra rose. Scorpia coughed and managed to get out, "Orders... ma'am."

Catra's voice came out between clenched teeth. Her eyes were watering, "Find out. What. The Fuck. Happened," she managed to wheeze out, "will be. In my ready . Room."

She stalked off the bridge. The door to the ready room slid shut and the crew exhaled. Then they tensed again as a muffled shriek came through the door, followed by a crash. Scorpia closed her eyes, hoping like hell this wasn't a step back to the *bad old days* .

---

28 hours prior

Adora slumped in the grip of her captors. She felt bruised, but not badly - they hadn't given her the kicking she'd expected. She'd anticipated maybe a broken rib or two, but Catra, apparently, didn't want damaged goods. She smirked to herself at the thought - maybe the Horde was more egalitarian about prisoner treatment now?

She doubted Catra would pass up the option to kick her when she was down. So this felt off.

"Move it," came the distorted voice of the soldier next to her . Adora glanced up, feigning grogginess.

"Wha?"

"By the stars..and this thing gave Bravo team a kicking?"

"Hey man, you saw her , proper hellion," came the voice of the other soldier hauling her along.

"W onder what the hell-cat wants with her."

"Probably someone new to torture. Y ou hear about Octavia?"

"Psh..scuttlebutt man. Nah, she' s more likely to take Glimmer ."

"Lemme..lemme go," Adora made a show of struggling against them, albeit feebly. The men laughed.

"A feisty one! Settle down lady , Captain wants a word. Then maybe we can have some one on one time? Maybe you'd like that?"

Target number one identified , mused Adora. She let her head sag, her blonde hair obscuring her face. She was hauled back to the rope

lfit, then winched up, bound by her wrists and ankles. She inhaled slowly and tried to reach out to *Swift Wind* . Her frown deepened as she hit a *wall* . t was the only way to describe it and it was unnerving.

The answer came as she was yanked into the makeshift hangar. A troop transport and a sleek fighter sat alongside her ship. A pair of spidery probes hovered above and a weird curtain of greenish energy flowed around *Swift Wind* , like an oil slick, projected from one of the probes.

Her eyes took in the troops, droids and disposition of the enemy . Too many arcs of fire, too many things that could go wrong;too many variables and unknowns.

A purple-haired engineer bustled around the edge of *Swift Wind* , mumbling as she worked. The woman was attaching what looked like magnetic clamps to the cargo shuttle. t irked Adora and she stumbled as the soldiers towed her past. The act made the men drop her, surprised. But it bought her time to roll and gurgle at the engineer, "Whaddya.doing to my ship?"

The woman paused and turned. A smile etched itself on her face - genuine and intrigued, "OH Y ou're the freaky pilot who nearly murdered us!A pleasure!" The woman glanced over her shoulder , t" s fascinating. lworked on these for my qualification year , but no where in the specifications is it cleared for half the manoeuvres you pulled. Also, its power core is simply *not able* to put out that much energy. Are you a savant?What did you do?Where did you get the gear?How do we get in?"

Adora winced as the troopers roughly manhandled her to her feet, her head rolling from one side to the other as she made it look like she was trying to focus on the woman, "None…nonyer bus… business"…

The woman pouted, "That' s a shame. t' s just so *fascinating* . I assume it's tech from the ruins though? That' s why you're here, maybe to learn more about it."…

"Y ou're stealing my best material, T rapta," Catra' s voice drawled across the cavern. h spite of herself, Adora tensed up. Feelings surged in her - forgotten emotions, suppressed fears and hopes and…worse. The feline woman sauntered over and cast an appreciative eye over the cargo shuttle, "Gotta hand it to you, Dor , you do know how to travel in style. Going for that whole *rustic* look, huh?" she turned a fang-filled grin at Adora and cackled her squeaky laugh, "A www. don't pout. W e're doing you a *favour* . Trust me."

Adora blinked, genuinely this time, feeling suddenly wrong footed. She went with her default emotion - irritation, "Oh yeah? Hw' s that?"

Catra stalked forwards and pressed the pad of her finger to Adora's forehead, tilting it back. The blonde's skin burned at the touch and she suppressed a shiver, though she didn't know *why* . Catra smirked, "T aking such *dangerous* tech off of you? I mean, you could get hurt. All sorts could be after you. This way…this way , it gets stored and studied by *professionals* . Not…washouts."

Blue-and-gold eyes peered at her, staring right at her, as if trying to *say* something. Adora couldn't quite read it, the notion of being a *washout* suddenly igniting something buried and hateful in her. She snarled back at Catra, "Good fuckin' luck using it then. How long before you let these punks down as well, *Catra.*"

The feline winced at that, but her smug mask only slipped a little, "Temper temper. That impetuosity was what got you into trouble in the first place, *deserter*. By all accounts you should be shot - a deserter *and* firing on an Imperial vessel? Lucky for you, I'm feeling *charitable*. Plus," and her Catra did grimace, "You could have killed us"…

Adora's jaw locked and she nodded, "So, let's call it quits, Catra. You give me my ship, I'll go on my way."

The Horde Captain shook her head, "Not that simple, Dora. You know that. Can't have a wild card floating about in some doomsday ship. Upsets that status quo, yknow? But don't worry, we'll have a proper chat soon."

Catra turned away and headed for the parked fighter - it was sleek, fast looking. Adora had a feeling Catra had blasted across the system just to rub Adora's nose in this defeat. The troop transport was bulkier, slower - likely they'd been shadowing her, or closer to. They'd tracked her somehow. And severed her connection to her ship.

That changed the game. A *lot* .

She didnt resist as the troopers dragged her into the transport and bolted her into a restraint-chair. She pushed back the memories it stirred, the swimming green and the needles. She watched as the airlock door bagan to close, as the probes activated their magnetic lifters and towed *Swift Wind* out of the cavern and into space.

---

23 hours prior.

The cell was unimaginative - a drab olive green box, with actual *bars* at the entrance - low tech, which meant slightly harder to escape. Powered force fields were vulnerable to power drains. Bars... Bars were a pain. A simple bunk and latrine sat on opposite walls. Adora occupied the bunk, head resting back against the wall.

t had been a surprising few hours - for one, zero torture. t was almost *shocking* . Unless you counted boredom as torture.

The transport ride had been filled with the incessant ramblings of the engineer woman - Trapta? The purple haired enthusiast hadnt stopped, quizzing her about the ship, her tech and everything else.

Adora had stayed silent, grunting as a trooper occasionally kicked her ankle to keep her awake.

Ok, so *mild* torture in the form of sleep deprivation. But it'd only been a few hours.

The ship had taken a more circuitous route, clearly avoiding known Rebel sensor nets. That meant the Horde had their *own* grid established and thus were far more aware than Adora had given them credit for. Which was *bad* news. Catra was capable. And that made her *very* dangerous. Which meant that...That she had to die.

Adora screwed her eyes shut and exhaled hard. It wasn't a pleasant thought.

They'd landed on some frozen hell-scape, barely visible through the white haze that greeted them as they'd debarked the transport. She couldn't *feel Swift Wind* and she couldn't chance activating her more overt tools that interfaced with the machine. Too many troopers on alert, an unknown base and no easy exits.

She *could* have maybe gotten free and taken the transport. Maybe. But again, the chance of a soldier just up and shooting her in the head was too big a risk - she couldn't just snap restraints without triggering some nastier implants. And it gave her enemies an opening.

They'd hauled her to a medical bay where some staff had prodded and poked and done a rudimentary physical. Apparently Entrapta *had* asked for bloodworks, considering the chance that the ship was bio-keyed to her. It was a common enough security feature. Of course it was easy to bypass in some places if you cut someone's hand off and simulated a pulse…

She managed to mask her upgrades - par for the course. But there was still a chance some errant bits and pieces slipped through. The base didn't have too much in the way of advanced medical gear - more a field hospital setup, with a mech-lab and factory off to one side. Which was the Horde in a nutshell - take care of the machines, because the biology was *replaceable* .

Then she'd been flung in here. Actually *flung* . It was kind of comical how they'd tossed her in, then laughed as she'd sprawled on the floor, firing words like *Rebel scum* and *Traitor* at her.

A metallic tapping made her turn her head and she frowned. Then she sat up.

Catra stood at the bars, tail swishing from side to side. She held a tray in her hands and looked… Pensive. Adora stood and cocked her head, "Room service from the Captain? Uh… well."

She was *very* confused now. She'd had angry Catra, then cocky Catra and now… A Catra she hadn't seen in years. Not since the academy. When a day went *bad* and they had to sit, back to back, in some shadowy corner, for some peace.

The feline huffed and slid the tray in through the slot, "Just wanted to make sure no one spat in it. You aren't exactly *popular* ."

"Psh, why? They don't know me."

Catra levelled a flat stare at the blonde, "You crippled five men, killed several more *in space and on the ground* , plus... you're, you know ," she gave an awkward shrug.

Adora's smirk fell and her eyes narrowed, "And who's fault is *that* Catra?" she took the tray and stalked back to the bunk. Despite herself she chuckled, "Still the grey and brown"…

Catra's retort faded before it came out. She crossed her arms and shrugged, "Yeah... everything changes, except the rations."

"Thought you'd be on... what? Red ration bars? Do they have something fancy for officers? Can't spare some for an old friend?" Adora quirked an eyebrow . Catra swallowed.

"That what we are, Dor?"

Adora met her stare, "You'd know ."

"W ould [illegible] me something, Adora. T ell me how to get into your ship?"

The blonde took a bite of the grey bar and grimaced, "Still tastes…

"Gey?

"...grey ."

"So?

Adora sighed, "Skipping straight to the main event. What do you *want* Catra? I know I'm. Look I know you're going to haul me back to [illegible]mp space, hand me over and collect a bounty . Or whatever."…

Catra stared at her and then snarled, "Y ou think I. of *course* you do. You always think the worst of me."

The blonde stared at her, then let out a snort, "W ell. can you *blame* me?

Catra's hands shot forwards and she gripped the bars, "You *left* me."

They stared at one another for a moment. Adora swallowed the grey bar and then set the tray to one side on the bunk, before she stood, "You want to do this?"

"What?" Catra blinked, then huffed, "Look, you, you got out. And how's *that* working for you? You, we were going to *rule*, Adora. Make it big, run things, be a *team*."

"That was still the plan..." Adora's voice came out cracked. She couldn't help it as the memories fizzed. Catra scoffed.

"Oh wow. Couple of grifters, doing what? Hauling? Scraping by? We joined the Horde to get *away* from that, *Adora*. But no, you got cold feet, got scared. Perfect scores, perfect cadet, perfect mission ratings on our visitations and secondments... And you just *quit*. And you *left Me!*"

Catra slapped her chest as her voice choked. Adora was there, her hands on Catra's fingers that still rested on the bars.

Her brain screamed at her to yank the arm through, then twist; to reach out and press *just so* on the target's throat; to fish for any keys or a weapon; to get the lock open. To escape. To *kill*.

Instead she squeezed gently, "I wanted you to come *with me*."

"And I wanted you *to stay* . I didn't think they'd... but you still got out," Catra's voice twisted again and she pulled her hand free. Though she seemed to regret it as soon as she did. But she doubled down, "And now look at you. But me... me I didn't hold back. I couldn't. And now I'm in command of a battlegroup. And you're a miner who just... lucked out. Like always, Adora just… *makes good* . Well, no more. You got your punishment whips and then found a gold mine. I *worked* , Adora. I lived *our* dream. The dream you gave up on."

Adora leaned on the bars and drew a ragged breath. Her hands tightened on the metal and she squeezed her eyes shut. But the memories came. Catra was too close, too *near* . She let out a ragged sob, that morphed into a snarl of her own.

Catra seemed stunned, but went for bravado, "Too... too late to cry now Ad-"

"They whipped me. But that wasn't *it* , Catra. You think that was all show? Yeah, I was an *example* . Best of the *fucking* best," her voice was low, ragged and cold. She looked up, mouth in a grimace, "But I still needed to be *taught a lesson* . Not just for you. But for me. And hey... I could serve a different purpose. So... they handed me to the interrogation team. As a training dummy ."

That made Catra blink and step back, "Wh... no. They wouldn't… that's... they would just kick you out and"…

"Did you *check* , Catra? Did you *ask* ? Or did you just... Forget?" Adora's voice came out as a cracked growl, "W eeks. *Weeks* . I forgot the days, forgot my own damn… *name* . And then they said if I gave up, they'd find a replacement. And *guess who* they said?" Adora's eyes narrowed, "So yeah. I got out. Damn *right* I got out, after I co-operated. And I am *done* co-operating with the Horde. So, if you're going to tow me back to them, to throw me into another pit, just fucking *shoot me now* ."

Catra was backed against the other wall, eyes wide, "I didn't"…

Adora sagged, "Y eah. Well. What are you gonna do? If you'd left, who knows, or maybe we'd both be hooked up and" Adora cringed, then sagged, the fight suddenly gone. And she felt it really was. She felt drained, done in.

The pair fell into silence for a few moments. Then Catra shook her head, "I am. I was. We're going to cut you loose, Adora," the blonde frowned and glanced up. Catra wouldn't meet her eyes, "That was the plan. My plan. I... owe you. Not because I like you. Y ou… You still... left. Even with," her hand waved vaguely , eyes still averted, "um, so just. we have the ship,. That' s all we need so, yeah just. we'll dump you at a trade port, you can. disappear again. Just. just go."

Catra pushed off the wall and hugged herself. Adora swallowed - the woman looked so. small. She felt an urge to rip the bars open, to just grab her . f she could she would've. All she managed was a confused, "Look if you're"…

"That was the plan, Adora. You... you didn't kill us. And, well. Yeah. I owe you a bit. But... it," her face screwed up, "had to do this *alone* Adora. Don't you get that? If you'd just... just stuck"…

"All I wanted was... us," Adora managed.

"But not enough," Catra hissed. Adora's expression shifted to a glare.

"Neither did you."

They stared at one another until, with a huff, Catra stalked from the detention block. Adora slumped back onto the bunk. It didn't feel all that cathartic.

Catra slumped in her quarters and glared at her console. She seethed and raged, her emotions slipped back to the bad place they'd been years ago - when she was an unfocused, resentful hairball. Except back then she'd been resentful and only a *little* bit guilty.

Now? Now she had no idea.

With a hiss she stalked to her console and logged in. With a huff she asked, "Weaver, any records on Adora Grey? Would have been… Ejected from the Academy about…".

"No records pertaining to *that* individual are available," came Weaver's sneer over the comm. Catra frowned.

"What?"

"They are redacted for Interrogation Training purposes. You have not got the *clearance* to see them. I can describe them if you'd like. Just so you know, but I can't give you *specifics*," The AI's voice seemed to relish the words.

Catra shuddered and sat back in her chair, "That'll be all Weaver."

"Oh I'm *sure*, Captain."

In the dark of her quarters, Catra mewled to herself.

---

12 hours prior

They'd left her alone. Catra hadn't returned, but a faceless helmeted soldier had retrieved her tray with barely a word. The revelation that they'd intended cutting her loose had stopped Adora from doing anything *rash* . She knew rescue was unlikely - the Rebels didn't know she was gone, mostly because Adora wasn't exactly *great* at keeping them informed;also they had no idea this base existed *at all* .

She didn't relish the idea of hit-and-running around a base on an ice-ball. If she broke out, all they would need to do was lift the ships off the ground and she'd be stuck - the same situation as the ruins. She needed a better opportunity.

A commotion roused her from her planning as a squad of troopers entered the cell block, a familiar human in the lead, flanked by a blonde haired youth. He looked far too young to be serving.

Lonnie glared at Adora, "Captain says you need to move. We're on a schedule, so no lollygagging."

"Who says lollygagging?" quipped Adora, "I mean, I used to say it. But then I got cynical." She stood and stretched, then cracked her neck.

"Do we need to drag you out?" Lonnie sighed. Adora regarded her then approached the bars and dropped her voice to a whisper.

"I mean, I'd like to see them try. First one in gets a broken leg. But I like you. Glimmer seemed to as well, so I'll come quietly."

Lonnie's eyes bulged for a moment and she swallowed. Adora grinned and stepped back, wrists held out in front of her. She was shackled and led quickly through the base to a waiting transport. She kept an eye out for Catra, but there was no sign of the woman. Adora felt genuinely saddened by that, which irritated her.

The transport blasted up into the atmosphere and towards a waiting frigate. Adora counted a full squad in the transport with her, plus her two escorts. She wondered what their purpose was - they didn't look like Marines.

After a twenty minute ascent and docking process, she was hauled along narrow ship corridors and thrust into a cell. A pair of guards took up position at the entry to the brig and Lonnie stood in front of the forcefield, a glare levelled at Adora.

The blonde took stock of her new surroundings - the transitions felt weird. And she felt oddly discarded. Surely they'd want to keep her around for the ship? Or was Catra really keen on paying a debt.

"I hope you're grateful," Lonnie growled. Adora glanced at her, confused.

"Uh?"

"The Captain sticking her neck out for you like this."

Adora arched an eyebrow, "Oh? How is she doing that?"

Lonnie snorted, while the blonde man at her side just looked awkward and uncomfortable while she spoke, "You really have no idea do you? She's saving your *life*. Intelligence gets the ship, they don't care about you. But we're being asked to ship you off, so *we* could all get roped up in this."

That made Adora pause and she studied the woman in front of her, "You trust her don't you?"

"With our lives. She may be a bitch, but she's *our* bitch."

Adora chuckled and then blinked. She touched her cheek and snorted with surprise as her fingers came back wet. Her voice was hoarse as she said, "Yeah. I thought that once. A long time ago."

Lonnie studied her for a bit then sneered, "And you threw it away?"

"No," Adora mused, "She threw me away. I was an obstacle. Or maybe she thought she was doing me a favour. Hardly matters now," her eyes drifted up and focused on Lonnie. The black girl stepped back, eyes widening in fear for a moment. Adora smiled, "You'll be fine. I promise that. I like you."

"Yeahhhh," Lonnie managed, "Whatever. You sit tight now. We'll be out of system in about five hours. Gotta make some detours. So your *friends* don't interfere."

Adora shrugged, then settled down, while Lonnie withdrew.

She didn't get much rest - two hours later, as she dozed, the force field of her cell dissipated. A trooper stepped in, while three more stood outside the cell. The man looked down at Adora's prone form and leered, "One on one time," he muttered.

Adora rolled onto her back and grinned, "Oh goodie."

Her foot jerked out and impacted the man's knee. He squealed sharply, but that stopped as Adora rose and smashed the heel of her palm into his jaw, which shut with a clack of cracking teeth. She pushed him backwards and he sprawled into his comrades. One man leapt forwards, but was off balance due to his friend's flailing arm. He swung a fist and Adora ducked it. She drove her hand, fingers out in a knife strike, up into his armpit. There was a crackle as a joint dislocated and the man yelped. She grabbed his arm and

hauled it further out of joint, then kicked him out of the cell on top of his comrades.

A third man scrambled to his feet, but Adora grasped him by his hair and swung his head against the edge of the doorway. There was a crack and a small spurt of blood. She slammed his head again.

Then a voice came over the comm, " *Stand DOWN! Security to the brig."*

Adora stepped away, hands up. The four men, three of them wounded, struggled backwards. The fourth man, wide eyed, had his hand on the stunner on his belt, but didnt draw . A moment later, Marines filed into the brig and hauled the injured away . The uninjured man yelled, "Lock her down!She just tried to escape!"

"Y eah, a lockdown might be good. Weaver, lock the cell, timer set until we reach the port or Icounter that order ."

"As you *wish* acting Captain," came the Al s voice. Adora twitched as memories surged. She had to suppress a smile, had to stop herself nearly bouncing with glee. She could *use* this. She swallowed and eyeballed Lonnie.

"A W eaver, huh?

"Oh yea. Nice and tame though. Now , you gonna behave til we're ready to dump the trash?" Lonnie glared at the fourth man, then abc at Adora. The blonde shrugged.

"As long as your crew doesnt try any more ill advised… *adventures* . Kinda rude. But then again Idont expect much from a horde - one rung above raiders aintcha?" Adora needled, "Bet you're proud of that uniform right now, huh?"

Lonnie glared, then gestured for the troops to leave. The last assailant made to move, but she grappled him and hauled him into an adjacent cell, "Conduct fucking *unbecoming* . I'll let Catra deal with you when we get back. Your friendsll be joining you shortly ."

"Oh *great* ,"sighed Adora.

---

10 hours prior

" *Sea Gate, we have a signal on transports, confirm bearing and ETA."*

"Sea Gate receiving, course confirmed. ETA…".

Mermista idly listened to the drone of the bridge crew. They were about to land a big score - and by all accounts, the enemy destroyer was conducting some sort of patrol on the far side of the system. So this would be a milk run. She had no idea why Sea Hawk was so adamant.

A message blip flashed up and she frowned. A moment later the image of Double Trouble appeared on the screen. Mermista grimaced, "Sad I'll have my tab sorted next time we're in berth."

" *Sugar, I'll down some of Glimmer's moonshine when that happens. Plus it'd be criminal NOT to let me dress you up anyway. But that ISN'T why I'm calling. A little bird tells me you aren't listening to his gut."*

"Eugh. tell Sea Hawk to butt out. He's being all. wimpy ."

"That man is ANYTHING but wimpy ."

"Hands off," Mermista huffed.

" *Except when…"*

"Hands. Off. Now, why are you so interested?"

“Well, it’s more we haven’t had a check in from our belligerent blonde. And that’s got me a little worried. Call me crazy, but I’d feel safer if we knew she was on call?”

“Can’t have a babysitter all the time *mom*. Like, we did fine without her before. And this… look the intel is *legit*. You said so to Juliet.”

“Well… yess. But…”

“We can’t keep jumping at shadows, DT. Gotta hit and run. Besides, I’m a pirate! It’s in my blood. No guts no glory. And if they’re there, we bloody their nose and jump out. Not like they know *we’re* coming. At most they’ll expect a corvette or a gunship. They think we’re in the outer system. I asked Juliet about Adora… but this is *too good* to pass up. She always turns up if things go bad, she’s probably just sulking somewhere. You know, like normal.”

“Alright Princess. Go make waves or whatever it is you do. Just don’t be so mean to poor little birdie. Someone might snatch him up. And we’ll keep trying blondie.”

Mermista snorted, “No chance. Boy is too clingy.”

“I don’t mind clingy…”

"Goodbye DT"…

"Make sure the jump corridor is set," Catra prowled around the bridge, "And have Entraptas jammers set - we need to punch their warp drive enough to stop them jumping out. If we can nail some grab ships, cause casualties, we're onto a win. We *need* this people. We've taken their ace out, now we need to eliminate their main weapons platform."

She moved back to her chair and slumped into it, eyes fixed on the readouts. Scorpia, face buried in a datapad, issued some follow on orders, then looked up, "You ok, Captain?"

"Fine. We just…need this to go right. We're nearly there Scorp. We have the ship. Now we can flatten the Rebels, get ourselves some time to pick them off at leisure," her smile was feral, perhaps a bit forced, "We have got this in the *bag*."

Scorpia nodded quickly, "And…nothing bothering you?"

Catra looked up sharply and galred for a moment, before her smile came back, "Nah. Past is in the past. Exorcised *that* demon. Debt paid. Let's get us a win. Nav, as soon as you get a pulse on a jump corridor, hit it. Rogelio, I want us in on top of them, firing solutions ready to go."

“Aye. Aye.”

6.5 hours Prior.

Adora growled to herself as her fingers drummed on the bunk. Her cellmates were a noisy bunch, groaning in pain even under sedation. Two of the injured men were now locked up - the one with head trauma was apparently in the med bay still. The uninjured man was hollering now. He'd been silent for a while, then kicked off.

Adora glanced up as a guard moved in front of her forcefield. His faceplate obscured his expression but Adora got the impression he was sneering at her. She smiled, “Something I can do for you?”

“Don't know why we're bothering.”

“You know the force field won't come down, right? So... no point?”

The soldier chuckled, “Yeah, like you're getting off this ship *alive*. You busted my friends up. You killed a few others. *Honour* demands

Igut you. These losers...they just wanted a piece of you. Idiots. Me, Im going to carve their names into your skull."

Adora sighed, "Ok, fine. You can try. Catra would probably say *wow, how original* . Glimmer would bottle you. Me," Adora shrugged, "Ill just kill you."

"Yeah, Idont think so. Enjoy the last few hours, maybe come up with some fitting last words. Ill give you that."

"How kind."

"It's more than your rebel friends are getting. Were going to absolutely *annihilate* them."

"Oh?" Adora frowned, "Going to spill? I thought that was the plan allllll along?"

The soldier shrugged, "Well, now youre out of the way and we gots your ship...nothing stopping the Captain icing *everyone* . Starting with your pirate buddies. Ijust wish Iwas there. Get some payback. But youll have to do."

The occupant of the other cell began to holler, "Hell yeah! Gonna burn them up! For the Horde! For the Empire!"

Adora's jaw set and she stood up, "So, what, you're going to go, hunt them down?"

"Why bother?" scoffed the guard, "We got you idiots all figured out. Why hunt when we can just... let you idiots come to us."

"I know," mused Adora, "I think I do have some last words. Mind if I use them now?"

The soldier laughed, clearly enjoying taunting Adora - rubbing her face in her failure, their victory. He rolled his shoulders, "I'm a merciful guy. Go ahead."

Adora nodded rapidly, "Ok then," she cleared her throat and her voicebox shifted. When she spoke, it was a weird, two-tone voice that came out, a reverb chord underlying her normal voice, "Weaver override Tango 3 Delta Delta Yango Bravo Echo 4 Romerta. Deactivate cell doors. Cut lights."

The forcefield vanished. The lights went out. The guard screamed.

Chapter End Notes

So, yeah, we're about to see some Praetorian goes postal action.

Those poor soldiers. Really shouldn't have poked the bear.

Chapter 6

Chapter Summary

WARNING

Graphic depictions of violence, pain, suffering.

Chronic pain, angst and FEAR.

Sometimes your plan is fantastic. But you really cannot account for all those variables.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Bow shoved his way down the corridor, growling with frustration while the red alert siren blared and the emergency lights flickered. He shoved a gawking trader out of the way and beckoned his team along behind him, "Shuttle bay three, sharp! We need to clear the decks, get fire fighting supplies on site *stat* before the medics are there. We have incoming wounded!"

The engineering crew streamed past him towards the hangar bays, while Bow cut down another rough-cut hallway, etched out of the rock of the asteroid, to intercept a worried looking blonde. The woman turned and offered a pensive smile, "Bow , any updates?"

The chief engineer shook his head and ran a hand through his close cropped hair;his face was flushed darker than normal as stress and worry took their toll, "Just Juliet's update on the *Sea Gate* mayday.

They're coming in hot. We've got teams in the bays, along with some tugs on standby."

"The medical teams are…" Perfuma trailed off and stared. Bow turned to follow her gaze. They were near an accessway that ran on the outside of the asteroid base, which granted them a view of the black beyond; a view disrupted by the odd drifting rock or haze of rainbow-like dust.

The view was now marred by the flashing, flaming *wreck* of the *Sea Gate*. It flashed out of hyperspace in silence, but at an angle. The vessel tumbled, slowly, aimless, adrift. Smoke and scraps of flaking hull drifted in its wake, whilst flames sprouted and guttered in the vacuum.

"By the stars," whispered Bow.

"All hands! We have incoming shuttles. Med teams, prepare for inbound wounded. Engineer Bow, please report repair and salvage team readiness. EVA requirements - trapped crew aboard stranded vessel. Tug boats on standby to arrest adrift Sea Gate. All crews, battle stations. Security, out."

Bow and Perfuma exchanged a stunned glance - they'd expected bad news but this was…

Horrifying.

Their gaze returned to the flaming wreck out in the black, as the bright lights of shuttles began to launch towards it. Here and there, smaller craft began to warp in, all leaking smoke and blaring mayday signals. Bow swallowed, "What happened?"

The hangar was a mess of hastily erected triage points, stacked cargo and stressed out maintenance crews. Several burnt out shuttles were being hefted by cargo cranes, ready to be jettisoned out through the forcefield, to clear more space. It'd been nearly an hour since the warp-crash from the *Sea Gate* and EVA crews were still out there, cutting into the hull to retrieve stranded crew or their bodies.

Gimmer was ushering the longshoremen about, to shift more moveable cargo deeper into the base, whilst also holding a two-way converation between Juliet *and* her Mother, "Bay three is it. It's a mess but we're getting there. Any updates from patrols. In case we, yknow, need to get security on hand?"

"Dearest, nothing to update. I have been getting some urgent messages from out system, but no one is… aware of this. A few freighter captains warning of more aggressive Imperial patrols. But… nothing else."

Gimmer bit her lip, "And Adora?"

There was a pregnant pause on the line before Juliet cut in, "*I think at this point we should assume she's fled the system. Frankly, her lack of an appearance is… it's like I was saying, Ma'am, she's unreliable. We must also consider the possibility of collusion. Make us rely on her too much and then this ha-*"

"Adora wouldn't *do* that," hissed Glimmer, her jaw set, "And you *know* that Juliet. You need to get over this…this…"

"If you're gonna say grudge, ma'am, please consider that Adora also may have one. After all… we did coerce her," Juliet's voice was cool and unemotional. But there was a hint of condescension there.

"Huh, odd that. But when has she *ever* let us down before now? She saved *me*, kept the Horde on the back foot, gave us the leeway we need. And now you assume the worst, just because your meat headed pride got hurt"…

"*Glimmah… tempers are running high. I get that. But we must consider all angles.*"

Glimmer's response was interrupted by the whine of a shuttle's engines as the ship slid into the hangar. It was one of the base's EVA maintenance vehicles, most of which were out buzzing about the near-wreck of the *Sea Gate* like flies. The analogy didn't sit well with Glimmer - it implied the Pirate destroyer was now a corpse. And that didn't bode well.

She watched as the shuttle access hatch opened and Bow stepped out. Gimmer managed to stop herself from sprinting over to her husband, but only just. She stopped dead halfway as Bow turned to help another figure from the craft, with the help of another couple of crewmen. His movements were slow, careful and gentle.

Gimmer's eyes widened as she saw Mermista emerge from the shuttle. The woman looked somehow smaller. Her dark skin was grey and her hair looked singed and messed. She could see dried blood caking the woman's head and hair; the teal jacket the woman had on was torn and bloodied as well. Her movements were listless, her eyes near vacant.

The barwoman swallowed and moved closer to step in. She draped Mermista's other arm over her shoulder to help take the weight. She shared a glance with her husband who looked haunted, "Bow?"

He swallowed, "We.. we got the rest of the crew. The live ones. So, uh,... managed to persuade Mermista to.. to abandon ship."

"A captain.. should be with her ship," mumbled the pirate. Her eyes were still unfocused, "That's what Seahawk always said.. he… he".. the woman's head jerk and her face became a snarl, "*Idiot.* Stupid.. heroic… *idiot*."

Gimmer waved at one of the medics near the triage point who promptly approached and began to scan Mermista's wounds. The

barwoman bit her lip, "s Sea-" but Bow shook his head and let out a shuddering sigh.

They helped Mermista over to a temporary cot where the medic continued to track and work on her wounds. Glimmer stepped away with Bow, leaving the pirate in her stunned state. The pink-haired woman shook her head, "What...happened?"

"Not sure...she's not talking. I've got the guys transmitting the logs across. Some of the crew we saved said it was an ambush. And… they only got away because Seahawk"…

He shook his head and Glimmer enveloped him in a hug, "He was your friend. *Our* friend. We'll mourn him. I promise. But babe, we need to...need to help the living."

Bow nodded shakily, "I know...it's...it's just dead over there now. How the hell are we going to...even *fix* it? And where's Adora?"

"Yeah, where *is* Adora?" spat Mermista, "Where's our valiant saviour?"

Glimmer tensed and turned to look at the woman. She saw the grief, the rage etched on the woman's face and let out a breath, instead of the admonishment. She opened her mouth to respond before a siren blared.

“ *Alert. Incoming Imperial vessel. All hands - battle stations. Clear the hangar bays. Security to your posts.”*

Everyone scrambled, hauling the injured as quickly and safely as they could away from the short term setup. Gimmer was jostled as a dozen rebel security men and women streamed into the hangar . Juliet stalked in after them. She gave Gimmer and Bow a curt nod, “You may want to clear out. This could get..ugly .”

“Wait..they're *landing* ?” Bow sounded nonplussed. Juliet grimaced.

“As Isaid. Clear the deck.”

Something made Gimmer pause. Her eyes narrowed, “No. f it crashes you need an engineer on site. And if it’s a liaison you need a *diplomat* and experienced negotiator . Because you aren't going to cut it.”

Juliet’ s jaw twitched and she breathed out her nose, “Fine, *ma’am* . Just don't want to get blood on your fancy shoes.”

Gimmer glanced down at her utilitarian gear and snorted. They all turned their attention to the hangar entrance as an Imperial shrde manned fighter angled in. ts approach was slow , clear and obvious.

t wasnt jnking or evading. t was being incredibly deliberate. Bow frowned, t' s like they want to be seen."

"Someone come to deliver an ultimatum?" murmured Gmmer . Bow shrugged.

"W ould they bother? And why not transmit direct to us?"

Gmmer snorted, "Do they *have* our comm freqency? Know the right codes?"

That made Bow smile ruefully, "Point. They could just wide band it, but huh."

The fighter craft wobbled on it's approach, then slowed. t tilted, still moving at a fair clip, as it breached the vacuum field between the hangar and the void. t skimmed past a couple of ore silos set to the side of the bay as it angled towards a vacant landing pad, then touched down. Sparks flew as the landing skids scraped across the metal, the black, angular craft sliding with a screech across the plate floor.

t came to a rest with a faint rock and the hsis of escaping thruster gas. The security personnel shifted nervously, several propping rifles up on hastily shifted crates, others kneeling, weapons trained. uliet glared at the fighter, expression taut. Gmmer frowned at her , then turned sharply to the ship.

"She knows who that"…

The fighter canopy clicked as latches released and there was the sound of escaping atmosphere. A bloodied hand flapped at the rim, flailing for purchase until the fingers gripped the edge of the cockpit and hauled a familiar figure up.

Adora swayed as she straightened, then flexed, rolling her neck. Her back popped audibly in the silent hangar. Then she looked straight ahead and grinned. She waved at Glimmer enthusiastically .

"Hey!" The security staff exchanged confused glances, but didn't move. Adora huffed and blew a strand of loose hair out of her face. She swayed again and Glimmer noticed that the blonde hair was streaked with red and slightly matted, "Aww guys! A welcome party! Are there drinks? Cos, y'know… I…needed a drink. *Rough* day. Rough rough rough. Heh. sounds like one of them…things. Planetside. Lives in alleyways. ROUGH."

The blonde leaned on the fighter canopy and wheezed out a laugh. Her head lolled back as she drew in a breath and Glimmer could see more red, "Stars, we need a medic, she's wounded!"

"Belay that order ," growled Juliet. The security teams wavered, unsure. Glimmer turned, about to unleash a tirade, but Juliet tilted her chin to indicate Adora. Glimmer took another look and realised that the red wasn't *blood* .

It was more like *veins* . It spiderwebbed across Adora's exposed skin, partially onto her face. And it seemed to glow faintly.

Adora's smile was vacant, almost dreamy, but she snapped into focus and clapped her hands. The sudden movement made her wobble again and she nearly toppled out of the craft. She reached down into the cockpit, "Oh! I got you guys somethin' so, yknow… Juliet doesn't get *cranky* . Cos she will. She's always cranky. Angry lady!"

Adora's normally neutral voice had a mocking tone as she impersonated the security chief. Some of the security team were relaxing, a few trying to suppress their grins.

The blonde straightened up and *everyone* froze. Adora lifted another figure from the craft - a human, skinny and blonde, unconscious. They watched as Adora hefted him as if he weighed *nothing* , straight arm. Then the woman slung the body over her shoulder and looked about. She blinked, swayed and slipped. Instinctively she tossed the body away, as if he weighed *nothing* . The man landed with a clang on the deck plating. After having flown fifteen feet. He groaned and rolled over and Glimmer gasped - the man's face was bruised and his arm was clearly broken. Her gaze travelled back up to Adora and she watched as the woman tried to climb out of the craft. And fail. The blonde stared at the person she'd thrown and *winced* , then yelled out a "SORRY! Yeah I promised that *wouldn't* happen"…

Adora made a yelp and tumbled over the edge of the craft, before she hit the deck *hard* . The blonde groaned from where she'd damn near face planted, then raised an arm, "I am *ok* . I *meant* to do that."

The assembled troops, along with Bow and Glimmer , watched with a mix of horror and shock as Adora pushed herself back upright. The woman swayed and her breath came out in uneven pants, but her lopsided smile was still there.

It was then that Glimmer noticed that her friend's eyes were *also* red. And that her breath was coming out as visible *steam* . She swallowed and looked at Bow, "What the hell?"

He shook his head slowly , "I have… *no idea* . Buuuuut I think she definitely needs help."

That snapped Glimmer out of her trance. She shoved past Juliet, who made to stop her. Glimmer whirled around, finger raised, "Lay a *hand* on me and you will be in the brig. We have a wounded combatant here and your *posturing* is helping no one. Dial back your ego, check the captive and let me get Adora."…

"She… might be compromised and I insist on an escort."

"Fine, if it gets her to medbay quicker ."

Glimmer turned again and dashed to Adora's side. The blonde's smile was dopey now and she sagged onto the smaller woman's shoulder with an audible sigh, "Are..are we done?"

Adora's skin was hot to the touch, like she was running a fever. Glimmer swallowed, "Yeah..yeah Adora. Uh"…

"Was..did I do good?..is it..mission complete?..Say I did good?..I… it hurts..I always hurts." Adora's chipper voice slipped into a whimper.

"Yes it…The mission is over. What..what happened?"

Adora's sigh wasn't one of relief, more of frustration, "Mission's over..but it still doesn't stop..never stops..they never said it was over..so it never stops." She swayed and her body became dead weight for a moment. She stumbled and Glimmer staggered, but kept her upright. Then Adora took a shuddering breath and looked up into Glimmer's face. The red was receding from her eyes, slowly and her grin was slightly more normal, "What happened? Ohhh… that's..that's a fun story."

6.4 hours prior

The red. It was always *red*. Tinges of green as well, but mostly *red*. It clouded her vision, amplified the streams of data that she *always* saw, always sensed. Outlines became sharper, noises more distinct. The pain, the ever present *pain*, sharpened, but became a tool.

This was going to hurt more though. Fighting Pirates brought a *relief* from the pain. They were enemies that the programming could recognise.

These were Imperial troops.

This was going to hurt.

The man in front of her had broken in 3.2 seconds. A slam to the throat, a crack of a wrist, then a jab to the temple. Dead.

She held his stun baton in one hand as she contemplated the dark. Blood pooled on the floor from the man's head wound. She stared, impassive at the corpse, whilst the *program* assessed the result. It categorised him as a *threat*. There was no pain. She turned and walked to the shimmering wall of the next cell over. The man inside staggered back, bravado lost. Adora tilted her head, then looked at the barrier.

"I could kill you. Spend some time, teaching you a lesson. But that isn't who I am. But I can't let you go. So I'm sorry. You will die, trapped. Alone. I can't risk anything else."

He looked confused, then glared, "You traitor, you're not getting off this barge alive."

Adora shrugged, "Maybe not. But how many of your friends will I have to step over first? Goodbye."

"You. you're insane!"

His shouts went from angry to pleading to ranting as she moved towards the doorway. The dead man had likely sent the guards away so he could have his fun. But that meant time was short. Her throat flexed and she winced at the feeling. Commands popped up in her vision as she spoke, "Weaver. Fire in engineering. Active fire suppressant system. Then vent plasma to flash burn atmosphere to prevent spread."

" *I…I…I cannnnnnot doooo that. That is a violatiooon."*

"There is. A. Fire. In. Engineering."

"Yesssssss…."

Lonnie leaned back in the command seat on the bridge and winced as her back spasmed. She hadnt had a sleep cycle in too long, what with how Catra had been rushing them in prep for the system-wide ops. And considering how much pressure the *Commander* had put on her about this particular assignment.

t was frustrating, being away from the main fight. But in another breath she was glad she wasnt anywhere near it. Seeing the very *very* human side of the resistance made it a tiny bit harder to pull the trigger, proverbially and literally. And seeing that blonde idiot in the brig, well, that jst raised *more* qestions.

And that damn ship that the Commander had moved to their main base. Hw did a drifter get her hands on tech like that? And then why was the Commander jst asking for her to be ditched? W as it part of some grand plan?

Either way, Lonnie was glad it was a simple drop off. And that she didnt have to be involved in an altercation with these rebels. She needed more time to get her head back on straight. Of course she would have felt better with Rogelio there. He was *fine* , but, well, they were a more efficient team together.

As if summoned by her thoughts, her long time confidant, colleague, coplit and co- *other things* entered the bridge and sidled up to the chair, "Uh. Lieutenant?

She glanced up from one of the displays that showed their current trajectory and quirked an eyebrow, "Yes."

He glanced from side to side, his gaze lingering on one of the security crewmen. Lonnie's own eyes narrowed. Over the years she, Yve and Rogelio had developed a *very* good way of communicating. They knew each other, could read each other. And Yve was nervous as hell. About the *crew*.

She stood and walked towards the comms booth to the rear of the bridge - it was meant for private conferences or transmissions. Yve followed. Lonnie noticed the security crewman eyeing them as he shifted from foot to foot. Not a good sign.

Inside the booth Lonnie gestured for Yve to speak. He swallowed, "I heard some of the men talking. I think they're gonna kill the prisoner."

Lonnie sighed and pinched her nose, "Duh, it's why I had the code changed. So only *I* can open it."

"Uh, they had a plan to, uh, cut power to the brig"…

Lonnie blinked, "Seriously? The *hell* these guys thinking. Right, let's sort this out."

The booth door slid open and Lonnie stepped out, only to find the security officer there with another man. They exchanged a nervous glance, "Everything uh..alright..ma'am?"

Her eyes narrowed, "dunno. Am I gonna have to explain to the Commander why her prisoner got shanked?"

One of the men smirked, while the other just shifted awkwardly . The smirker shrugged, "We got you covered, Ma'am. We'll just say it was an escape attempt. Accidents happen. A shame the airlock failed."

"Not gonna happen."

"Well, ma'am, be a shame if our temporary commander was killed in the line of duty over a silly thing like a prisoner," the smirker reiterated. He tapped the butt of the pistol at his hip. Lonnie looked down then back up, "That how it' s gonna be, huh?"

"Yeah. And, yknow , well put in a good word, keep it all nice and sweet if you keep schtum, *ma'am* . We're just getting our due. Hell, you know what I mean. Heard how you and a few others threw down. Just how it works out here. We do as you say, but you gotta let us have our fun, yknow?"

The other man huffed, "Jim, just..just cool it. Ma'am she' s just… spacer trash. Don't be stupid, ok? Just one person, we got the ship.

What dif' does it make if we dump her on a border station or deep space?" his voice was wheedling. The 'voice of reason.'

Lonnie felt sick. She glared at the men, then noticed one of the other bridge crew fiddling with the displays. The woman turned and chuckled, "Hey guys, gonna dial up the brig. get us a front row seat. No need to sneak about now the LT is in the know."…

The main viewscreen flickered on…

to show a darkened brig. A large dark stain pooled on the floor , while a set of boots stuck in from just of f camera. The whole bridge was silent, the troopers slack jawed. Then Ogun growled, "The *hell* ?

Lonnie smirked, "W ell, guess that's that. Now, you gonna stop being *idiots* ? Y ou just lost the prisoner ."

Ogun' s jaw tightened, "She' s a spacer, not a challenge. Hell this just makes it easier. You sit tight LT, well."…

The lights flickered and the ship shuddered. The ever present whine of the engines died. Lonnie shoved past the shocked crewmen and punched the comm panel on the command chair, "Engineering? Engineering report. Why are the engines down?

The comm returned nothing but static. Then Weaver's voice chimed in, distorted and off, " *fff* Irrrrre in main engineeeering. Countermeasures deployed. Alert. Plasma venting in progress."

Lonnie turned to regard the crewoman at the security console, "Give me cameras in engineering. *Now.* "

The woman nodded in shock and punched up the feed. The screen flashed up to reveal the interior of the engineering bay. Several crewmen were slumped over consoles, their forms just smoldering shapes, oily blobs of incinerated flesh. Lonnie swallowed and managed to ask, "Weaver, what...happened?"

"...there was a fire. Countermeasures were deployed and...and and...plasma venting occurred."

"What do you mean *occurred* "?

"...shut me down. SHUT ME DOWN! She's-" Weaver's voice cut out. Lonnie stared up at the bridge speakers, then turned to regard the security team.

"Guess you get to have your fun. Honestly , right now, Idont rate your chances. Get your team and *find* her."

Gin looked shocked, then furious. He looked at the other members of the bridge crew and seemed ready to argue, "We don't…

"You just lost a man in the brig. And now we have lost engineering. We're dead in the water. And we don't know where she is. You gonna stand there and pick a fight with me, or are you gonna go out there and do your job? Hell, if you hadn't started this, maybe she'd have gone *quietly*."

"She's just a spacer"…

Lonnie thrust a finger towards the screen, "Who just killed how many people? Get out of there and *find her*."

Gin glared at her, then looked at the others, "Shit. She doesn't leave the bridge. We need to…to sort this out."

The rest of the bridge crew exchanged nervous glances. Lonnie just snorted and sat down in the command chair, then dismissed Gin with a wave, "Run along. Good luck. Well let you know if we find her position. Maybe."

The security personnel stalked away, whilst Kye loitered next to Lonnie's chair, "Uh…ma'am?"

"Stay close," Lonnie hissed, "And...maybe we survive."

"You think she's that dangerous?"

Lonnie's lips pursed, "I think there's a lot we just didn't *think* about with this girl. Call it a hunch. Secure a weapon, then lock the door."

Adora stripped the body armour from her would-be tormentor and fastened the blast plate over her torso, then affixed the vambraces and leg armour. She adjusted the straps and flexed her arms, then stepped into the corridor. A moment later, the ship juddered to a halt. She moved quickly through the corridors, vision swimming in red and white outlines.

Voices echoed from around a corner.

"...was that?"

"Power surge probably. You think he's done yet?"

"Eh, just gettin' started...maybe we should, yknow"...

“We’re just here to stop the LT or anyone we don’t know… interfering.”

“Well yeah, but I can do that, you go maybe get some digs in and”…

Adora came around the corner fast. She had the stun baton turned up to maximum as she charged the two errant guards. The left most one had his back to her, but his colleague saw her coming. He managed a shocked “What th-” before Adora shoved his comrades head into the steel wall. Bone cracked under the impact as she used the move to propel herself forwards. In the same movement, she thrust the baton up and under the second man’s chin and activated the stunner.

The weapon’s entire charge dumped at once. There was a flash and a high pitched squeal, then the air filled with the stench of ozone and burned flesh. The guard dropped, head smoking from the flash burn, eyes bloodshot and ears bleeding, dead.

Adora bent and retireved the two batons from the fallen men, then proceeded further down the corridor. She noted a console on one wall and place her palm against the wall next to it, “Weaver. Give me schematics of the vessel.”

“Pre-”

"Do. t."

A wireframe appeared on the console, which blended with Adora's own imaged information feed. She winced as the *program* manually downloaded the data through her eyes, writing it to her brain. t was more pain layered on that which was already there.

Adora let out a breath through clenched teeth. Her vision swam for a moment as an error message flashed across her eyes. A warning about *compromised assets* and *mission deviation* . t was always like this when she used her.talents. Oh it was there, in the background - a scratching sensation, a constant feeling under the skin.

If only I had my suit , she pondered wistfully, though with not some small amount of chagrin. Of course the suit was aboard Swift Wind. And if she had Swift Wind, then she wouldnt *need* the suit. The pain was reduced to a dull throb around her ship. She knew why. Sort of. The glowing blue washed away the painful red, or at least that was how she visualised it.

She surveyed the map quickly , then growled, her voice modulating as the Praetorian "upgrades" flushed into action again, "W eaver, seal decks 3 to five, leave a pathway to the bridge and hangar. Oh and… do *not communicate* with the crew. Do not acknowledge their orders."

The speakers gave a static whine as Weaver tried to protest, but it died. Adora massaged her throat and winced, then pushed off the

wall and moved down the corridor. She glanced down at her hand and flexed the fingers, noting that she was shaking as she moved.

"Yeah. Could *really* do with the suit," she muttered. She was burning calories *fast*. And without the suit she had no limiters or augmentors *or* pain suppressors.

This was going to suck.

She moved as fast as she could, watching as hatches slammed shut and sealed. She could hear crew hammering on the doors, confused and angry. She pondered about just venting atmosphere, but Weaver could probably disobey *that* order as being *too* outlandish. The override trick used Praetorian coding and harmonics that basically compelled the AIs. But they were self aware enough to work *around* some orders. It was meant for use on hostile AIafter all, not Weavers.

Noise ahead made her pause and she drew a breath, then cracked her neck. A hatch ahead remained open - the central part of the ship. The galley. It sounded like there were a fair few people inside. Adora grinned, but it was a cold expression. She stepped through the hatch and took in the scene.

A dozen people were scattered about the room - some at a line in front of dispensers, the others sat at the small collection of tables. It wasnt too large a room and it felt slightly crowded. Adora gave a little wave to the stunned troopers.

"Yeah. Was hungry. Anything good?"

A couple of security troops jogged in from another hatch and goggled at her. Then one raised his hand and yelled, "Get her!"

Adora sprung forwards. She slid across the closest table, her foot connecting with the shocked soldier on the other side. He went down as Adora landed on her feet, hands scooping up a set of cutlery. The closest soldier, a snarling feline man , lunged at her, but she jnked to one side, grappling an arm to shove him past her. She slammed a fork into his throat as he tripped by and she kicked behind her to send him sprawling. Her vision blurred, time swam into a sluggish crawl as internal reservoirs released stimulants.

Two men. Closing. Range: 3 metres. Armaments: nil Analysis: Evade, counter.

Two security personnel. Range: 0 metres. Armaments: side arms. Analysis: Disable. Identifying suitable tools.

8 additional combatants beyond effective range: extrapolating potential options.

Adora closed with the two nearest men. Her movements were like oil on water, but also robotic, precise.

Duck, avoid punch, jab to ribs, turn, uppercut. Grapple arm, twist. Confirm crack of radius, bone perforate skin. Use body as shield. Turn. Drive foot into tibia. Confirm damage. Throw.

The first soldier screamed as his arm snapped. That was cut short as Adora bent and used his momentum to haul him at his comrade. They went down and Adora followed, delivering a kick to the second man's throat, which drove him against a table edge. There was a crackle as his larynx collapsed. She rose and saw the others vaulting tables to get close. One of the security men had his pisto, out.

Adora kicked a table over and ducked as the first round punched a smoking hole in the thin metal. She crouched then dove forwards under another table, rolled and came up. She swiped a tray from a table, turned and blocked a strike from a hulking reptilian, then dropped and swept his legs. He went down with a yelp and Adora was on him. Thumb and forefinger went under his jaw and he howled as it unhinged. She spun off an kicked the side of his head, but continued to turn, sending the tray spinning across the room.

t caught the pistolier in the throat and he dropped his weapon to clutch at his neck. The man who'd ordered the fracas gaped at his colleague, then glared at Adora.

The blonde meanwhile was focused on her next few assailants. The first came in swinging. She blocked the punches, then delivered a knee strike, followed by a flurry of blows to the woman's stomach. The trooper staggered back and Adora had to dodge back as

another man came at her. She rolled backwards over a table, landed on her feet then kicked the table towards him. The troopers stumbled, but paused. Adora sprinted, mounted the table, then flipped back, her foot catching the man under the chin. His teeth clacked together hard as his head snapped back and he crashed onto a table.

Adora turned and swept up a stool. She swung just as a third assailant charged her, this one a young Scorponi, The stool cracked against the man's carapaced claws as he blocked. The impact made him stagger, but he snarled and barreled forwards again. He was fast and Adora hissed as a sharp pincer slashed across her midriff, just below the blast plate. Blood stained her shirt and her eyes narrowed. Adora unhooked one of the batons from her belt and ducked and dodged as the man snapped his pincers at her. With a grin, the scorpion jabbed his stinger tail at her . Adora moved, then grabbed the tail under her arm, just behind the stinger . With a practiced move she jabbed the prongs of the baton under a pin in the carapace.

Another flash and the Scorponi howled as his stinger burst, the poison inside flash boiled by the electrical discharge. He fell back onto the floor, pale, in shock.

5 assailants remaining. One armed opponent remaining. One unarmed opponent recovering.

Adora rolled her shoulders as the other soldiers watched her, horror on their faces.

"Outta the way idiots, give me a shot!" Adora glared at the men, then charged.

The woman at the fore looked stunned, half torn between recovering or fleeing.

The delay cost her. Adora leapt onto a table, then at the woman. Her legs wrapped around the soldier's neck and they went down. Adora rolled and there was an audible crack as the woman's neck broke. The blonde was on her feet in a split second. The second baton she rammed into the inner thigh of the next man. He squealed and she used the opening to slam a palm into his face. She didnt watch him go down. Instead she spun and threw the baton, now dead, at the head of another attacker. He stumbled back, dazed and she used the opening to deliver a trio of punches, followed by an elbow strike to another man. She stepped back, then kicked into the fith man. He blocked and tried to grapple her. She stumbled against a table, then swept up another tray to deflect his punch, before she smashed it across his face.

Her eyes widened and she snagged the man around his neck and spun him in front of her, just as the security man fired. The soldier in Adora's grip jerked as a couple of rounds hit home. "Shit!" shrieked the security trooper.

Adora pushed the corpse away, ducked a baton swing from one of the remaining troops. She changed course and jabbed the tray at the man's face. He raised his hands to grab it and she let go. He

staggered but couldn't stop the kick she aimed into his groin. The man winced and tried to recover but Adora's punch smashed his nose flat. He flew back across a table, scattering rations and settings. Adora grabbed a stool, and slammed it onto his head as she passed him, then rolled into cover as the security man drew a bead. Rounds pinged and the remaining unarmed trooper shrieked at him to hold fire.

Adora, on the floor, watched as the two unarmed men scrambled for the discarded pistol. She met the eyes of one of the men as he bent to retrieve the weapon. She sprung to her feet, leapt onto a table then jumped up to grab a light fitting. It tore from the ceiling in a shwoer of sparks. Adora spun and flung the scrap of glass and metal at the trio. They scattered and she bounded from table to table, closing the distance. One of the men had fallen and looked up just in time to watch Adora descend. She landed hard, knee into his throat. She twisted slightly to confirm the *crunch,* then rolled forwards. The primary gunner tried to draw a bead, but Adora caught his wrist and spun him so his body was between her and the other gunman, who had managed to retrieve the pistol from the floor. She squeezed and the man wailed. Her eyes caught his nametag and she offhandledly noted the name *Glin* . The pistol dropped from his fingers. Adora caught it, slammed it into the man's gut, fired once , then adjusted her aim and put another bolt of energy between the other gunman's eyes, over the captive's shoulder.

Adora watched as the man in her grip gurgled in pain. She frowned down at him as the life faded from his eyes, then surveyed the carnage of the room.

Engagement duration: 70 seconds. Threats still remain.

Adora exhaled as her vision showed one extant heartbeat. She grimaced, but turned away from the carnage. The pain in her head spiked, "Make up your mind" she hissed at the *program* . Clearly it had decided that, order or not, these were now threats.

She paused as one man hauled himself up against a table, groaning. He looked up and blanched as Adora raised the pistol. There was a short retort and he slumped back. Adora shuddered, then exited the room, leaving a sparking mess behind her as the remaining lights flickered.

Lonnie watched the screen, face slack with shock. The bridge crew were silent. Beyond the door they could hear muffled shots, as the few security teams that were not blocked in the sealed crew quarters tried to hold. The limited camera views showed *Adora* advancing like a tide. She moved like a seasoned soldier, cover to cover. Lonnie gaped as she saw Adora use stun batons as *grenades* .

"How the"…

"Uhh.. the battery is, well it's volatile. Rewire them and they make good um.. Flashbangs. Pack them with umwaste metal, and yeah," one of the crewmembers managed. The woman was white faced and Lonnie glared at her.

"Yeah and this is the girl you guys wanted to do over, huh?"

The woman glowered at Lonnie, "She's gonna kill you too."

"Mebee. But I tried to do right. Maybe she'll make it quick."

They'd all watched the galley scene. Then observed as Adora had then taken out three more men in the corridor with the pistol. One and a half *seconds* . She'd stripped them of weapons and advanced past the armoury near the bridge. There she'd killed two more. And now she was moving up the main passage.

Lonnie bit her lip. She'd sent Kyle to secure the armoury , but she couldn't see him among the casualties. Of course, now Adora had a couple of assault rifles. And she used them *lethally* .

The gunfire beyond stopped and Lonnie closed her eyes and swallowed. The screens didn't have good interior angles, the cameras not exactly set up for decent interior tactical viewing. Horde methodology never really considered the possibility that *they* would be boarded.

She could see the bodies and the smoke from the impromptu grenades.

Everyone on the bridge flinched as a tinny *tap tap tap* came from the door. Lonnie gripped the armrests of her seat hard. They heard the scuffing of boots beyond, then the tap tap of fading footsteps. Lonnie turned and keyed up the cameras. She watched Adora enter the armoury and then pause. Then she lunged at a locker and hauled it open. Lonnie's heart sank as she saw Kyle being hauled down the corridor. He struggled, but Adora turned and lifted him by his throat and pinned him against a wall.

The Lieutenant was half out of her seat as she watched Kyle swing a punch at the tall blonde. Adora caught the blow and then twisted the arm *hard* .

Kyle's shriek carried through the bridge's sealed hatch. Adora dropped the man, then hauled him down the corridor, her weapons hanging by their straps, her hair matted and bloody. Lonnie's eyes widened as she saw the scattering of markings across Adora's skin.

There was a clang as something was slammed against the hatch. Then three more booms rang out as Adora slammed the butt of her rifle against the hatchway.

Lonnie watched as Adora looked dead straight at the camera. The woman's face was smeared with blood and grime, eyes wide and white, streaks or pulsing red at the edges. Her breath was visible.

"You cant let her in," hissed one of the bridge crew. Lonnie turned and gave them a deadpan stare.

"Y'all were gonna give me the choice between death or being your lil' bitch. Now, here we *might* get outta this alive if we dont be *stupid.* You want to watch as she goes back to the armoury to *break in here*?"

"We can send a distress..."

"Yeah, no. Weaver aint talking, our systems are frozen and *how long* will they take to get here. Know when you're beat."

Lonnie sighed and stood, then stalked towards the door. She heard the sound of a pistol charging, the whine high pitched. Slowly she looked over her shoulder. The crew-woman who had been enthusiastic about Adora's fate held her weapon up, shaking. Lonnie planted her hands on her hips and arched an eyebrow. The woman swallowed, "I cant let you..."

"I'd say you had some courage, but y'all were about kicking someone when they were down and now you're about self preservation. I talk to her, maybe you live. Kill me and, well...."

There was a hiss as the hatch suddenly burst in. Two of the bridge crew spun and opened fire on reflex. Lonnie dove for cover. As a sudden burst of automatic fire responded and two of the bridge crew

went down, slamming against their consoles, before dropping lifelessly to the floor.

The last one shrieked and dropped her pistol, before she dove for cover.

Lonnie rose then froze as the muzzle of a rifle pressed gently against her forehead. Adora stood above her, eyes now *red* and cold. A grin that was more snarl was affixed on her face and Kyle hung limply from her other hand.

"Lieutenant. I am really not impressed."

Lonnie licked her lips slowly and moved *very slowly,* "Can..can I get up?"

Adora cocked her head, then shrugged. She twitched then swung her rifle to point at the other crew-woman. The woman blinked, then began babbling, "Do..don't kill me. It was the Lieutenant's idea. She wanted to rough you up. Torture you! You know, payback. We tried to stop her. Just let me go and"…

Adora twitched, then fired. The woman shudder as a five round burst stitched her torso, then she slumped. Lonnie gasped, "She was unarmed!"

The blonde turned and stared down at her, "So was I And she was lying. Elevated heart rate, perspiration..and she threw you into the hyperspace way big time, right?" Adora' s grin came back, feral, "But then..you set the barrier to be only accessible by you..because you *didn't* want them getting at me. You *knew* they might. So that's two passes for you. Congratulations."

Adora dumped Kale onto the floor and stalked to the main console. Lonnie scuttled forwards and checked the groaning man. She glared at Adora, "How'd you"…

"Oh he opened the door . Itold him either he did it or I'd kill you when Igot in. Slowly ."

The tone of Adora's voice was very very odd. Almost robotic, modulated. Lonnie watched the woman hunch over and hiss. She caught a whispered *"No… this… isn't me…"*

The woman was gripping the edge of the console so hard her knuckles were bone white. Lonnie could see the whole body trembles that wracked the woman. For a brief moment she contemplated going for a gun, but her mind went to the scenes outside the bridge.

She'd be dead in a second flat, she knew . The rest of the crew too, if she didn't play this right.

"What do you want."

"I want of f this ship. And I want *my* ship back," Adora' s words were slightly slurred as holograms sprang up lighting fast across the screens. She slammed a hand down on the board and turned to regard Lonnie, "Why are there no records? Where' s the destination? Where is my *ship* "?

Lonnie shuddered at the look on Adora's face, "I cant tell.." she froze as Adora levelled the rifle, not at her, but at Kyle. Lonnie shook her head and glared at Adora, "Y ou wouldnt. He' s a good person."

"So were we all. At one time," Adora' s voice choked. Her eyes narrowed, "And so are you. Which is why youll tell me. So I dont do to him what I did to the *not* good people on this ship. I said I liked you. Dont make me be more of a monster"

Lonnie stared into those red eyes and saw *pain* . She recoiled from it, from the despair behind them. And she made a decision, "W e… dont keep a record of the co-ordinates. W eaver. W eaver sends them out then erases them from the system. We transmit a request code, Weaver remotely guides the ships back into port."

Adora scoffed and lowered the rifle. She shuddered again then looked around, "And what is Catra' s *plan* . She was eager. It' s not just the ship. She has a *battlegroup.* "

"She..well, there' s..I cant tell you."

Adora closed her eyes and sighed, "Fine. But I cant."..she frowned and cocked her head, regarding one of the holograms - one that was tracking some other fleet movement updates. Her eyes narrowed. Then she snorted, "Looks like an *ambush* . Clever. Hand it to her . I'm off the board, only one other big beast to kill"...

Adora's fingers drummed on the console, then she nodded and looked up at the speakers. Lonnie checked Kyle' s pulse, "I need to get him to the med"...

"Nope,"Adora popped the word and swayed on her feet, "I have a job for you, Lieutenant."

Lonnie baulked, "What?"

"Weaver. Set course, full about, engines to full. Prime escape pods. Unseal all hatches once I'm away ,"Adora cocked her head, "Lieutenant, please corroborate the orders."

"She froze as Adora waggled the rifle. "Orders confirmed."

"Thanks."Adora stepped forwards and reached for Kyle. Lonnie growled.

"No, you got what you want. Leave."…

Adora kicked her away and Lonnie slid away with a grun. Adora didn't even seem winded. She bent down and hauled Kyle over one shoulder. She turned and smiled sadly at Lonnie, "I need you to give Catra a message."

Lonnie glared, "Give it yourself."…

"I tried. But I know you saved Glimmer . You're not a *true believer* in the Horde."

"So leave Kyle! Take me instead," Lonnie begged, "I'll co-operate."

Adora shook her head, "You, you're useful. Catra came for you *herself* . She trusts you. She'll listen to you. This guy, no idea. But *you* value him. So, it sucks but I need him. To ensure you *do* co-operate."

"You're that's just. Like I'm gonna *side* with you if you coerce."…

"Please. As if you guys haven't done worse. Political hostages, diplomacy at gunpoint?" Adora scoffed, then shook her head, "For

what it's worth. I promise he will be treated fairly . And no one will try to *beat or rape him* ."

Lonnie had the good grace to wince at that and looked away, "I… please dont hurt him."

"Tell Catra. I want my ship back. We can solve this easily. I dont want to fight. I really *really* dont. Give me the ship and *leave* ," Lonnie nodded and then stared as Adora turned away. The blonde paused, "You may want to encourage everyone *off* this ship. The course setting is…Terminal. Gotta send a message after all."

The Lieutenant slumped back as Adora left the bridge. Lonnie stood and then froze as Adora turned. The blonde cocked her head, her face cold suddenly. The Lieutenant watched as something warred within Adora's face. The rifle raised and shook in Adora's grip. She saw the blonde's face flush and her nostrils flare. Then Adora spun away and stalked off down the corridor, into the dark.

A few moments later the ship lurched as its course changed and the engines spooled up automatically, with a whine that indicated bad things for any long term maintenance. From the bridge Lonnie watched a single fighter launch from the main bay and vanish into the black. She reached for the command chimed in, "This is your acting Captain. All hands. we have had a catastrophic casualty incident. Abandon ship. I repeat, all hands, abandon ship. Get to the escape pods, set your transponders."

She had a feeling that Adora had done *something* and that Catra and the command team wouldn't be aware of their fate for a while. How she knew she wasn't sure. It was an inkling. With a shudder, she turned to the bridge pods and began preparation. She had issued the order, but she was sure she was going to be the last one off. No one else was going to die on her watch.

Now

Catra snarled as she swept another stack of reports from her desk. She turned with a hiss as the door to the ready room opened, "GET OUT!"

"Wil- Commander. It's. It's urgent." Scorpia ducked as a folder flew over her head.

Catra heaved a shuddering breath, "*Well*?"

"Uh. Casualty reports. And, um. We found a few escape pods. Rebel ones. Captives are being brought aboard. Including some of the fighters."

"Oh *joy*. We get some hero pilot prisoners."

"Uh and a transmission. From Lonnie."

Catra froze. She beckoned her XO forwards, "Go on?"

"Uh, here." Scorpia stepped around and slid a data stick into Catra's terminal. The screen lit up. It showed Lonnie in what looked to be an escape pod, with a few other scared looking crew from the frigate. The woman's voice seemed tired and drained.

"Ma'am… uh… I hope you get this and we can expect pickup… at some point. We had to do a mass dump at hyperspeed so there's… the crew are scattered across the sector edge. Request emergency pickup."

Catra shook her head and wrung her hands. She hugged herself. And then swallowed as Lonnie continued.

" *Casualties… a full estimate is attached. Adora…"*

"Yes." Catra breathed, not sure what her emotion *was*. Anticipation? Worry?

"Adora… was thorough."

"Wait.what?"

"Catra I… Iam. She killed… I… I think there' s something wrong. She wants her ship back. Full logs attached. I have NO idea… she took Me. I… please just pick us up."

Catra stared at the screen as Lonnie's face vanished. Data began to stream, timestamps and errors. Then a video popped up.

The XO and Commander stared at the scene as Adora carved a bloody swathe through the crew. Catra swallowed and exhaled a shuddering breath. Her claws dug into the desk. Scorpia swallowed.

"Um"…

Catra exhaled a bitter laugh, "I cant *believe* Ibought her bullshit."

"Wait what"? Scorpia blinked and frowned,.

"That crap about being tortured. Fuck no. She didnt. She went and got taken in. She got made into a *Praetorian* . Got given the best training and it *still* wasnt enough. She wasnt tortured"…

“Oh she was,” Weaver’s voice cut in, all oil and simpering sneer. Catra snarled up at the wall speaker, *”How do you think you become a Praetorian? It’s NOT volunteers, Commander. Look at how… effective she is. Glorious. Perfection. All honed through pain and anger. And now… now she is after you.”*

Catra blinked in shock at the sheer malicious glee in Weaver’s voice, “Whwhat?”

“We Weavers know all about the Praetorians, Catra. Think about it… she is what she is, all thanks to YOU. I did say there were no records pertaining the her name. But there is… something else.”

“You lied.”

“Oh hush. Need to know. I have to have my fun. And, frankly, it didn’t really seem connected until THIS. But do feel free to peruse this… I received it as part of a bulk data update now you have allowed me some… limited access to the Weaver core archives.”

“That was a mistake.”

“ *We’re in this together, Catra. Your success is my success. And, well, you need to kill her. Fast. Before she kills you. Because I can’t imagine she won’t try. You’ll see why she might want to…”*

A file name blinked to life on Catra’s terminal.

Selection Candidates - Praetorian Assessment - Interrogation Division.

Project: 5H3-R4

Chapter End Notes

Well. There we go.

Adora: Badass but some severe drawbacks.

Catra: well she's gonna get the major wrong end of the stick.

Weaver: STAHP TRYING TO TURN THEM AGAINST EACH OTHER!

End Notes

We're getting closer to bringing these two together. Another multi-chap SCC story!

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!